Tao Te Ching

LAO TZU

Tao Te Ching

the book of the Way and its virtue

ANNOTATED EDITION

Translated by James Legge
with a plain-language note on every chapter
and a 30-day practice

INTRODUCTION AND NOTES BY ANDREAS RUPP

Tao Te Ching (Annotated)
The Classic James Legge Translation – with a Plain-Language Note on Every Chapter, a Guide to Taoist Ideas and a 30-Day Practice

The *Tao Te Ching* (in Legge's spelling, *The Tâo Teh King*) is traditionally attributed to Lao Tzu. This edition uses the English translation by James Legge (1815–1897), first published in 1891 in *The Sacred Books of the East*, which is in the public domain. Legge's wording, his numbering of the verses and his words in round brackets are kept; obvious printing errors are corrected.

Introduction, guide to Taoist ideas, a note on every chapter, practices, the 30-Day Practice, the Quick Finder, the glossary, the afterword, cover and interior design © 2026 Andreas Rupp. All rights reserved.

Please note: This book is about a spiritual practice. It is not medical, psychological, financial or legal advice. The practices in this book can go alongside professional help, never instead of it. If you are ill or in crisis, please see a doctor or a qualified professional. In an emergency, call 911 (US) or 999 (UK).

Edited by Andreas Rupp

Sincere words are not fine; fine words are not sincere.

LAO TZU, CHAPTER 81

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How to Use This Book

The *Tao Te Ching* is short. You could read all eighty-one chapters in an afternoon, and many people do. But it was never meant to be rushed. Most chapters are only a few lines long, and each one rewards slow attention far more than speed.

So here is a simple suggestion: read one chapter a day. Read it twice. The first time, read it silently and let the words pass through you without trying to solve them. The second time, read it aloud, slowly, as if you were speaking to someone in the room. You will be surprised how often a line that seemed strange on the page becomes clear once you hear it in your own voice.

This edition is built to support that kind of reading.

The full text. You will find all eighty-one chapters in the complete translation by James Legge, first published in 1891. Nothing has been shortened or modernized. Legge's English can feel heavy at first, which is exactly why each chapter comes with help.

After each chapter you will find three short pieces. The *Reflection* says in plain modern words what the chapter is about and what it might mean in an ordinary life today. The *Practice* offers one small, concrete thing to try, usually something that takes a few minutes. The *Key Line* picks out a phrase from Legge's text worth carrying with you through the day. There is space below for your own notes.

The 30-Day Practice is a guided month in four themes: stillness, softness, simplicity, and leading without forcing. Each day gives you one line from the text and a short task. You can use it alongside your daily chapter or on its own, once you have read the book through.

The Quick Finder lists common situations, such as feeling overwhelmed, facing conflict, or leading a team, and points you to the chapters and practice days that speak to them.

The Glossary at the back explains the key ideas of the book and the older words in Legge's English, so you never have to stop and wonder what "the ten thousand things" or "attemper" means.

There is no wrong way to use this book. Skip around, return to favorite chapters, or let a single line keep you company for a week. The text has been read this way for well over two thousand years.

About Lao Tzu and the Text

Tradition says the *Tao Te Ching* was written by a man called Lao Tzu, a name that simply means "Old Master." Who he was, and whether he was one historical person at all, is a question that scholars still debate.

The oldest account of his life comes from the Chinese historian Sima Qian, who wrote around 100 BC, several centuries after Lao Tzu was supposed to have lived. Even Sima Qian was unsure. He reports that Lao Tzu's family name was Li, that he served as a keeper of archives at the royal court of Zhou, and that Confucius once came to consult him. Then he adds other possible identities, as if admitting that the stories did not quite fit together.

The best-known story is a legend. Tired of the decline he saw around him, the old archivist rode west toward the frontier. At the mountain pass, the gatekeeper, Yin Xi, recognized him as a wise man and would not let him leave until he had written down what he knew. Lao Tzu sat down, wrote a short book in two parts, handed it over, and rode on. No one saw him again. It is a lovely story, and it should be read as one.

What scholars find in the text itself points in a different direction. The *Tao Te Ching* looks less like a book written in a single sitting and more like a collection that grew over time: sayings, short poems, and teachings that were gathered, arranged, and polished, probably between the fourth and third centuries BC. Archaeology supports this. Bamboo slips found in a tomb at Guodian, sealed around 300 BC, contain parts of the text in a different order. Silk manuscripts from a tomb at Mawangdui, dated to 168 BC, contain the whole book, with its two halves in reverse order.

Those two halves give the book its name. The first part, chapters 1 to 37, is traditionally called the book of the *Tao*, "the Way." The second part, chapters 38 to 81, is the book of the *Te*, usually rendered "virtue" or "power": the quiet strength a person has when living in harmony with the Way. *Ching* means "classic" or "scripture," a title given to books of great authority. So the *Tao Te Ching* is, roughly, "The Classic of the Way and Its Power." In early times it was simply called the *Lao Tzu*, after its supposed author.

The book became one of the foundations of Chinese thought. Together with the writings of Chuang Tzu, it shaped the philosophy later called Taoism, and it was taken up by poets, painters, rulers, and hermits alike. A religious Taoism also grew up over the centuries, honoring Lao Tzu as a divine figure. The book left a deep mark on Chinese Buddhism, especially the tradition known in Japan as Zen. It was read alongside the teachings of Confucius, often as their gentle counterweight: where Confucius stressed duty, ritual, and learning, the *Tao Te Ching* spoke of letting go, simplicity, and returning to what is natural.

The book reached the West slowly. Jesuit missionaries in China studied it in the eighteenth century, and a French translation by Stanislas Julien appeared in 1842. The first full English version, by John Chalmers, came out in 1868, and James Legge's followed in 1891. Today the *Tao Te Ching* is among the most translated books in the world.

Taoism in Brief

You do not need any background to read the *Tao Te Ching*, but a few key ideas will help you find your way. Here they are in plain words.

The Tao. *Tao* means "way" or "path." In this book it points to the deep pattern of how things are: the source everything comes from, the flow everything follows, and the place everything returns to. The very first chapter warns that the Tao that can be put into words is not the real one. It is not a god to be worshipped or a rule to be obeyed. It is more like the grain in a piece of wood: you can work with it or against it.

Te. *Te* is usually translated "virtue," but it does not mean being morally correct. It is closer to the old sense of the word, as when we speak of the virtue of a medicinal plant: its natural power. Te is the quiet strength of a person who lives in tune with the Way. It does not show off, and it does not need to.

Wu wei. This is the book's most famous idea. Literally "not doing," it does not mean laziness. It means acting without forcing: doing what a situation needs, no more, and then stepping back. Think of a good teacher, a skilled craftsman, or a calm parent. Things get done, yet no one feels pushed.

The soft and the hard. Again and again the book says that the soft overcomes the hard and the weak overcomes the strong. A young plant bends; a dead branch snaps. Rigid things break. Flexible things last.

Water. Water is the book's favorite image. It is soft, it yields, it always flows to the lowest place, and yet over time it wears away stone. It gives life to everything and asks for nothing.

The uncarved block. The text often speaks of wood that has not yet been shaped into anything. It stands for our natural, unspoiled state, before we cover it with roles, ambitions, and cleverness. Returning to it means returning to simplicity.

Simplicity and few desires. The book does not ask you to give everything up. It suggests that wanting less is a form of wealth, and that knowing when you have enough brings a peace that no possession can.

Emptiness. A cup is useful because it is hollow. A room is useful because of the space inside it. The book asks us to value empty space, in our schedules and in our minds, as much as what fills it.

The sage. The *Tao Te Ching* often describes "the sage": a wise person, sometimes a wise ruler, who lives by the Way. The sage leads by staying in the background, teaches without lecturing, and does good without taking credit.

Yin and yang. These famous terms appear only once in the Chinese text, in Chapter 42, where Legge renders them "the Obscurity" and "the Brightness." Yet the book is full of their spirit: dark and light, soft and hard, female and male, each giving rise to the other. Neither side is bad. Wisdom lies in knowing both and keeping them in balance.

A Note on This Translation

James Legge (1815–1897) was a Scottish missionary who spent some thirty years in Malacca and Hong Kong. He came to China to preach, but he stayed to study, and he became one of the great scholars of Chinese literature of his age. After returning to Britain, he was appointed the first professor of Chinese at the University of Oxford in 1876.

His translation of the *Tao Te Ching* appeared in 1891 in *The Sacred Books of the East*, a famous series of translations edited by Max Müller. It forms part of volume 39, *The Texts of Taoism*. Legge himself spelled the key words "Tâo" and "Teh" and called the book *The Tâo Teh King*; in the notes of this edition we use the familiar spellings Tao and Te.

Two features of his translation are worth knowing before you start.

First, the **round brackets**. Classical Chinese is extremely compressed, and a literal rendering often makes little sense in English. Legge added words to fill the gaps, but he was honest enough to mark them. Whatever stands in round brackets is his own addition, not the original Chinese. You can read straight through them, or skip them to get closer to the bare text.

Second, the **rhymed passages**. Where Legge felt the Chinese was poetry, he sometimes turned it into rhymed English verse. These passages are set as lines of verse in this edition. They can sound old-fashioned, but they remind us that much of the book was meant to be chanted and remembered.

Why read Legge today, when there are so many newer versions? Because he tried hard to show what the text says rather than what he

wished it said. His English is careful, close, and unhurried. It slows you down, and with this book, that is a gift.

Tao Te Ching

EIGHTY-ONE CHAPTERS · TRANSLATED BY JAMES LEGGE

Chapter 1

1 The Tao that can be trodden is not the enduring and unchanging Tao. The name that can be named is not the enduring and unchanging name.

2 (Conceived of as) having no name, it is the Originator of heaven and earth; (conceived of as) having a name, it is the Mother of all things.

3 *Always without desire we must be found,*
If its deep mystery we would sound;
But if desire always within us be,
Its outer fringe is all that we shall see.

4 Under these two aspects, it is really the same; but as development takes place, it receives the different names. Together we call them the Mystery. Where the Mystery is the deepest is the gate of all that is subtle and wonderful.

REFLECTION

The book opens by admitting its own limits. Whatever the Tao is, the word "Tao" is not it. Any name we give is a handle, useful but partial. Unnamed, the Tao is the source of everything; named, it becomes the "Mother" we can talk about. Both are the same reality seen from two sides. The rhymed lines add a practical point: when we come to life wanting something from it, we only see the surface. When we stop grasping, we see deeper. For a modern reader, this is an invitation to hold our labels lightly, including the labels we put on ourselves, other people, and our problems. The map is helpful. It is not the territory.

PRACTICE

Pick one object near you, like a cup or a plant. Look at it for one minute without naming it or its parts in your head. When a word appears, let it go and return to simply looking. Notice what you see that the label usually hides.

KEY LINE

The name that can be named is not
the enduring and unchanging name.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 2

1 All in the world know the beauty of the beautiful, and in doing this they have (the idea of) what ugliness is; they all know the skill of the skilful, and in doing this they have (the idea of) what the want of skill is.

2 So it is that existence and non-existence give birth the one to (the idea of) the other; that difficulty and ease produce the one (the idea of) the other; that length and shortness fashion out the one the figure of the other; that (the ideas of) height and lowness arise from the contrast of the one with the other; that the musical notes and tones become harmonious through the relation of one with another; and that being before and behind give the idea of one following another.

3 Therefore the sage manages affairs without doing anything, and conveys his instructions without the use of speech.

4 All things spring up, and there is not one which declines to show itself; they grow, and there is no claim made for their ownership; they go through their processes, and there is no expectation (of a reward for the results). The work is accomplished, and there is no resting in it (as an achievement).

The work is done, but how no one can see;
'Tis this that makes the power not cease to be.

REFLECTION

We only know "beautiful" because we also know "ugly," and "easy" only makes sense next to "hard." Opposites define each other, like front and back. Once we see this, our judgments lose some of their grip. The sage, the ideal person of the book, works without fuss and teaches more by example than by talk. The chapter then looks at nature: things grow, do their work, and never claim credit. The closing verse says the work is done and no one can see how, and that is exactly why its power lasts. Today this speaks to anyone tired of constant self-promotion. Good work done quietly often outlives loud work that keeps asking to be noticed.

PRACTICE

Do one helpful thing today without telling anyone: wash a colleague's mug, fix a small problem, send an anonymous thank-you. Afterward, notice any urge to mention it. Let the urge pass and keep the deed to yourself.

KEY LINE

The work is done, but how no one can see;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 3

1 Not to value and employ men of superior ability is the way to keep the people from rivalry among themselves; not to prize articles which are difficult to procure is the way to keep them from becoming thieves; not to show them what is likely to excite their desires is the way to keep their minds from disorder.

2 Therefore the sage, in the exercise of his government, empties their minds, fills their bellies, weakens their wills, and strengthens their bones.

3 He constantly (tries to) keep them without knowledge and without desire, and where there are those who have knowledge, to keep them from presuming to act (on it). When there is this abstinence from action, good order is universal.

REFLECTION

This is one of the book's political chapters, and it can sound harsh. It advises rulers not to put talented people on pedestals, not to glorify rare goods, and to keep people "without knowledge and without desire." Written for kings in a time of constant war, the point was social calm: if you inflame ambition and greed, you get rivalry and theft. "Knowledge" here means clever scheming, not education. A modern reader rightly values schooling and free choice, so it helps to read the chapter inwardly. Notice what in your own life stirs envy and restless craving, and whether you keep feeding it. A fed belly and strong bones, simple needs met, may matter more than another bright desire.

PRACTICE

For one day, mute or unfollow three accounts, ads, or feeds that mostly make you want things or compare yourself. At the end of the day, write one sentence about how your mind felt with less input.

KEY LINE

not to show them what is likely to excite their desires is the way to keep their minds from disorder.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 4

1 The Tao is (like) the emptiness of a vessel; and in our employment of it we must be on our guard against all fulness. How deep and unfathomable it is, as if it were the Honoured Ancestor of all things!

2 We should blunt our sharp points, and unravel the complications of things; we should attemper our brightness, and bring ourselves into agreement with the obscurity of others. How pure and still the Tao is, as if it would ever so continue!

3 I do not know whose son it is. It might appear to have been before God.

REFLECTION

The Tao is compared to an empty vessel. A bowl is useful because it has space in it, and the Tao is like that: it never fills up and never runs dry. The chapter then gives advice that sounds simple and is hard to follow: blunt your sharp points, untangle knots, soften your glare, and blend in with ordinary people. In plain terms, do not be the most cutting voice in the room. The last lines say the Tao seems older than anything, even older than God, Legge's word for the ancient Chinese supreme ancestor-deity. Today the chapter can be read as advice for leaving room, in a schedule, a conversation, or a mind, instead of filling every space to the brim.

PRACTICE

In your next conversation, notice the moment you want to make a sharp point or correct someone. Pause for one breath instead. Ask a question or simply listen. Afterward, note whether anything was actually lost.

KEY LINE

We should blunt our sharp points, and
unravel the complications of things;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 5

1 Heaven and earth do not act from (the impulse of) any wish to be benevolent; they deal with all things as the dogs of grass are dealt with. The sages do not act from (any wish to be) benevolent; they deal with the people as the dogs of grass are dealt with.

2 May not the space between heaven and earth be compared to a bellows?

'Tis emptied, yet it loses not its power;
'Tis moved again, and sends forth air the more.
Much speech to swift exhaustion lead we see;
Your inner being guard, and keep it free.

REFLECTION

This chapter is famously cool. Heaven and earth, it says, are not "benevolent." They treat things like straw dogs, figures used in ancient rituals and then thrown away. Nature is not cruel; it simply does not play favorites. The sun shines on everyone. The sage is meant to be just as impartial. The second image is a bellows: empty inside, yet the more it moves, the more air it gives. Then a warning: too much talking wears us out, so guard your inner life. For us, this can be a relief. The world is not personally against you. And there is strength in being less reactive, saying less, and letting your center stay quiet.

PRACTICE

Choose a one-hour block today and speak only when needed: no small commentary, no extra explaining. Breathe slowly in the gaps. At the end, notice whether you feel more tired or more rested than usual.

KEY LINE

Your inner being guard, and keep it free.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 6

The valley spirit dies not, aye the same;
The female mystery thus do we name.
Its gate, from which at first they issued forth,
Is called the root from which grew heaven and earth.
Long and unbroken does its power remain,
Used gently, and without the touch of pain.

REFLECTION

This short chapter is a single rhymed image. The "valley spirit" never dies. A valley is low, open, and receptive. Rivers run into it, life grows in it. The chapter calls this the "female mystery," a mother-like source from which heaven and earth came. Its power is long-lasting because it is used gently, without strain. The Tao Te Ching often prefers the receptive to the aggressive, and this is a clear example. In daily life, the valley stands for openness: the ability to receive, to listen, and to let things come to you. Not every good outcome needs pushing. Some things grow best in a space that stays open and quiet.

PRACTICE

Sit for five minutes and imagine yourself as a valley: low, wide, open. Let sounds, thoughts, and feelings flow in and pass through without blocking or chasing them. When you notice tension, soften the shoulders and belly.

KEY LINE

The valley spirit dies not, aye the same;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 7

1 Heaven is long-enduring and earth continues long. The reason why heaven and earth are able to endure and continue thus long is because they do not live of, or for, themselves. This is how they are able to continue and endure.

2 Therefore the sage puts his own person last, and yet it is found in the foremost place; he treats his person as if it were foreign to him, and yet that person is preserved. Is it not because he has no personal and private ends, that therefore such ends are realised?

REFLECTION

Why do heaven and earth last so long? Because, the text says, they do not live for themselves. The sky and the land simply support life without asking for anything back. The sage follows the same pattern: puts himself last and ends up first, treats his own concerns lightly and is kept safe. It sounds like a paradox, and it is meant to. The final question goes further: perhaps it is precisely because he has no private agenda that his aims come true. For modern life, think of the colleague or friend everyone trusts because they are not always angling for something. Letting go of self-interest often earns more respect than chasing it.

PRACTICE

In one meeting, meal, or group chat today, let others speak first and take the smaller portion, the later turn, the less visible role. Do it without resentment.

Later, notice how others responded and how you felt.

KEY LINE

Therefore the sage puts his own person last,
and yet it is found in the foremost place;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 8

1 The highest excellence is like (that of) water. The excellence of water appears in its benefiting all things, and in its occupying, without striving (to the contrary), the low place which all men dislike. Hence (its way) is near to (that of) the Tao.

2 The excellence of a residence is in (the suitability of) the place; that of the mind is in abysmal stillness; that of associations is in their being with the virtuous; that of government is in its securing good order; that of (the conduct of) affairs is in its ability; and that of (the initiation of) any movement is in its timeliness.

3 And when (one with the highest excellence) does not wrangle (about his low position), no one finds fault with him.

REFLECTION

Here is one of the book's central images: the highest good is like water. Water helps everything it touches, and it flows to the low places everyone else avoids. It does not argue about its position, and so no one blames it. That, the chapter says, is close to the Tao. A list follows of what makes things good: a home in a fitting place, a mind with deep stillness, friends of good character, government that keeps order, work done with skill, action at the right time. Today water offers a model for kindness without ego. Be useful, take the humble task, choose your timing, and skip the quarrel. Strength does not always look like fighting for the top spot.

PRACTICE

Fill a glass with water and watch it for a minute. Then choose one low, unglamorous task today, one others tend to avoid, and do it well without comment. Notice how it feels to be useful without needing recognition.

KEY LINE

The highest excellence is like (that of) water.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 9

1 It is better to leave a vessel unfilled, than to attempt to carry it when it is full. If you keep feeling a point that has been sharpened, the point cannot long preserve its sharpness.

2 When gold and jade fill the hall, their possessor cannot keep them safe. When wealth and honours lead to arrogancy, this brings its evil on itself. When the work is done, and one's name is becoming distinguished, to withdraw into obscurity is the way of Heaven.

REFLECTION

Do not overfill the cup. A vessel filled to the brim is hard to carry, and a blade sharpened again and again soon loses its edge. A hall full of gold cannot be guarded forever, and pride in wealth or status brings its own trouble. The closing line is the heart of it: when the work is done and your name is rising, step back. That is the way of Heaven. Modern culture often pushes the opposite: more, bigger, longer, louder. This chapter suggests knowing when enough is enough, whether in work hours, possessions, or ambition. Stopping at the right moment is not failure. It is a skill, and it protects what you have built.

PRACTICE

Pick one thing you tend to overdo: emails, edits, snacks, scrolling, polishing a project. Today, stop one step before your usual point. Leave the cup a little unfilled and notice what happens.

KEY LINE

When the work is done, and one's name is becoming distinguished, to withdraw into obscurity is the way of Heaven.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 10

1 When the intelligent and animal souls are held together in one embrace, they can be kept from separating. When one gives undivided attention to the (vital) breath, and brings it to the utmost degree of pliancy, he can become as a (tender) babe. When he has cleansed away the most mysterious sights (of his imagination), he can become without a flaw.

2 In loving the people and ruling the state, cannot he proceed without any (purpose of) action? In the opening and shutting of his gates of heaven, cannot he do so as a female bird? While his intelligence reaches in every direction, cannot he (appear to) be without knowledge?

3 (The Tao) produces (all things) and nourishes them; it produces them and does not claim them as its own; it does all, and yet does not boast of it; it presides over all, and yet does not control them. This is what is called 'The mysterious Quality' (of the Tao).

REFLECTION

This chapter asks a series of questions. Can you keep mind and body together as one? Can you make your breath soft and supple, like a baby's? Can you clear your inner vision until nothing distorts it? Can you lead and love people without forcing them? Can you be receptive, like a mother bird, and know a great deal while not showing off? The ancient language of "souls" and "vital breath" belongs to early Chinese thought about the person, and here it works as an

image of wholeness, not a health claim. The chapter ends by describing the Tao itself: it gives life and does not own, acts and does not boast, leads and does not control. That is a striking model for parents, teachers, and managers.

PRACTICE

Three times today, stop and take five slow breaths, letting each exhale be soft and unforced. Then think of one person you guide or care for, and ask: where can I support them today without trying to control them?

KEY LINE

it presides over all, and yet does not control them.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 11

THE THIRTY spokes unite in the one nave; but it is on the empty space (for the axle), that the use of the wheel depends. Clay is fashioned into vessels; but it is on their empty hollowness, that their use depends. The door and windows are cut out (from the walls) to form an apartment; but it is on the empty space (within), that its use depends. Therefore, what has a (positive) existence serves for profitable adaptation, and what has not that for (actual) usefulness.

REFLECTION

A wheel has thirty spokes, but it turns because of the empty hole at its center where the axle goes. A clay pot is shaped from material, but we use the empty inside. A room has walls, but we live in the open space between them. The conclusion is simple and deep: what is there gives us benefit, but what is not there makes things usable. This may be the most practical chapter in the book. Free time in a calendar, silence in a conversation, an empty shelf, a pause before replying: these are not wasted. They are what makes the rest work. We tend to value only what we can add. This chapter reminds us to value space.

PRACTICE

Clear one small space completely: a drawer, a corner of your desk, or thirty minutes in tomorrow's calendar. Leave it empty on purpose. Over the next few days, notice how that empty space gets used, or simply how it feels.

KEY LINE

Clay is fashioned into vessels; but it is on their empty hollowness, that their use depends.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 12

1 *Colour's five hues from th' eyes their sight will take;*
Music's five notes the ears as deaf can make;
The flavours five deprive the mouth of taste;
The chariot course, and the wild hunting waste
Make mad the mind; and objects rare and strange,
Sought for, men's conduct will to evil change.

2 Therefore the sage seeks to satisfy (the craving of) the belly, and not the (insatiable longing of the) eyes. He puts from him the latter, and prefers to seek the former.

REFLECTION

The rhymed opening warns that too much stimulation dulls the senses. Endless colors blind the eye, endless music deafens the ear, endless rich flavors ruin taste. The thrill of racing and hunting drives the mind wild, and chasing rare treasures leads people to behave badly. The sage chooses the "belly" over the "eyes," meaning real, simple needs over endless wanting. For a culture of screens, notifications, and constant novelty, this ancient advice lands close to home. It does not condemn pleasure. It says pleasure piled on pleasure stops being pleasure. Satisfying what you actually need, and letting go of what merely catches your eye, can bring back the ability to enjoy.

PRACTICE

Eat one meal today with no screen, no music, and no reading. Taste each bite slowly. Notice the flavor, the texture, and the moment you are actually satisfied, and stop there.

KEY LINE

Therefore the sage seeks to satisfy (the craving of) the belly, and not the (insatiable longing of the) eyes.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 13

1 Favour and disgrace would seem equally to be feared; honour and great calamity, to be regarded as personal conditions (of the same kind).

2 What is meant by speaking thus of favour and disgrace? Disgrace is being in a low position (after the enjoyment of favour). The getting that (favour) leads to the apprehension (of losing it), and the losing it leads to the fear of (still greater calamity):—this is what is meant by saying that favour and disgrace would seem equally to be feared.

AND WHAT is meant by saying that honour and great calamity are to be (similarly) regarded as personal conditions? What makes me liable to great calamity is my having the body (which I call myself); if I had not the body, what great calamity could come to me?

3 Therefore he who would administer the kingdom, honouring it as he honours his own person, may be employed to govern it, and he who would administer it with the love which he bears to his own person may be entrusted with it.

REFLECTION

Praise and blame, the chapter says, should be treated with the same caution. Winning favor makes us afraid of losing it, and losing it makes us afraid of something worse. Both keep us anxious. Then a bold question: the reason I can be hurt by fortune is that I cling to a self that can be hurt. If I were less wrapped up in that self, what disaster could touch me? The text is not asking us to

neglect ourselves. It ends by saying that someone who cares for the world as much as for his own body can be trusted with it. Today, the chapter speaks to anyone ruled by likes, reviews, or the boss's mood.

PRACTICE

The next time you get a compliment or a criticism, silently say "noted" and wait ten seconds before reacting. Notice how strongly your sense of self wants to grab it, and see whether you can hold it more loosely.

KEY LINE

Favour and disgrace would seem equally to be feared;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 14

1 We look at it, and we do not see it, and we name it ‘the Equable.’ We listen to it, and we do not hear it, and we name it ‘the Inaudible.’ We try to grasp it, and do not get hold of it, and we name it ‘the Subtle.’ With these three qualities, it cannot be made the subject of description; and hence we blend them together and obtain The One.

2 Its upper part is not bright, and its lower part is not obscure. Ceaseless in its action, it yet cannot be named, and then it again returns and becomes nothing. This is called the Form of the Formless, and the Semblance of the Invisible; this is called the Fleeting and Indeterminable.

3 We meet it and do not see its Front; we follow it, and do not see its Back. When we can lay hold of the Tao of old to direct the things of the present day, and are able to know it as it was of old in the beginning, this is called (unwinding) the clue of Tao.

REFLECTION

We look and do not see it, listen and do not hear it, reach and cannot grasp it. The Tao slips past every sense, so the chapter calls it the “form of the formless.” It has no front to meet and no back to follow. This is not meant to frustrate us. It is a reminder that the deepest things are not objects we can hold. Yet the chapter ends practically: if we hold to the ancient Way, we can handle the present day, and knowing where things begin gives us the thread through the

maze. In modern terms, step back from surface details and look for the underlying pattern. The root of a situation often explains more than its noise.

PRACTICE

Take one current problem and write it down. Then ask three times, "What is underneath this?", writing a short answer each time. Look at the last answer. Does it suggest a simpler place to begin?

KEY LINE

We look at it, and we do not see
it, and we name it 'the Equable.'

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 15

1 The skilful masters (of the Tao) in old times, with a subtle and exquisite penetration, comprehended its mysteries, and were deep (also) so as to elude men's knowledge. As they were thus beyond men's knowledge, I will make an effort to describe of what sort they appeared to be.

2 Shrinking looked they like those who wade through a stream in winter; irresolute like those who are afraid of all around them; grave like a guest (in awe of his host); evanescent like ice that is melting away; unpretentious like wood that has not been fashioned into anything; vacant like a valley, and dull like muddy water.

3 Who can (make) the muddy water (clear)? Let it be still, and it will gradually become clear. Who can secure the condition of rest? Let movement go on, and the condition of rest will gradually arise.

4 They who preserve this method of the Tao do not wish to be full (of themselves). It is through their not being full of themselves that they can afford to seem worn and not appear new and complete.

REFLECTION

The old masters of the Way are described in a string of images: careful like someone crossing a winter stream, alert like someone aware of danger, polite like a guest, loosening like melting ice, plain like uncarved wood, open like a valley, murky like muddy water. Then comes one of the book's best-known

questions: who can make muddy water clear? Let it be still, and it clears by itself. The point is that many troubles settle when we stop stirring them. The masters were not full of themselves, and so they could stay worn and unfinished rather than shiny and new. Today this is a gentle permission to stop forcing clarity and let it come.

PRACTICE

Stir a spoonful of soil or coffee grounds into a clear glass of water. Set it down and watch it settle for a few minutes. While it clears, let one worry sit untouched in your mind, without trying to solve it.

KEY LINE

Let it be still, and it will gradually become clear.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 16

1 The (state of) vacancy should be brought to the utmost degree, and that of stillness guarded with unwearying vigour. All things alike go through their processes of activity, and (then) we see them return (to their original state). When things (in the vegetable world) have displayed their luxuriant growth, we see each of them return to its root. This returning to their root is what we call the state of stillness; and that stillness may be called a reporting that they have fulfilled their appointed end.

2 The report of that fulfilment is the regular, unchanging rule. To know that unchanging rule is to be intelligent; not to know it leads to wild movements and evil issues. The knowledge of that unchanging rule produces a (grand) capacity and forbearance, and that capacity and forbearance lead to a community (of feeling with all things). From this community of feeling comes a kingliness of character; and he who is king-like goes on to be heaven-like. In that likeness to heaven he possesses the Tao. Possessed of the Tao, he endures long; and to the end of his bodily life, is exempt from all danger of decay.

REFLECTION

Empty yourself as fully as you can and hold to stillness. Then watch: everything rises, grows, and returns to its root, like plants that flourish and go back into the soil. Returning to the root is stillness, and the chapter calls it the fulfilling of one's course. Knowing this constant pattern brings clear sight. Not knowing it

leads to reckless moves and trouble. From that knowledge grows a wide, patient heart that feels at one with all things. The closing promise of lasting "without decay" is best read as an image of inner steadiness, not a promise about the body. For a modern reader, the chapter offers calm in the face of change: cycles turn, and everything comes home.

PRACTICE

Go outside, or look at a plant indoors, and find one sign of a cycle: a fallen leaf, a new shoot, a wilted flower. Spend two minutes with it. Then name one thing in your own life that is currently returning to its root.

KEY LINE

When things (in the vegetable world) have displayed their luxuriant growth, we see each of them return to its root.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 17

1 In the highest antiquity, (the people) did not know that there were (their rulers). In the next age they loved them and praised them. In the next they feared them; in the next they despised them. Thus it was that when faith (in the Tao) was deficient (in the rulers) a want of faith in them ensued (in the people).

2 How irresolute did those (earliest rulers) appear, showing (by their reticence) the importance which they set upon their words! Their work was done and their undertakings were successful, while the people all said, 'We are as we are, of ourselves!'

REFLECTION

The chapter ranks leaders. The best are barely noticed. Next come those people love and praise. Then those they fear. Worst are those they despise. When leaders do not trust the Way, people stop trusting them. The best leaders speak sparingly and weigh their words. When their work is done, people say, "We did this ourselves." This is one of the most quoted passages on leadership, and it travels well from ancient courts into offices, classrooms, and families. A good leader creates conditions in which others succeed and feel ownership. The goal is not to be admired. It is for people to grow so capable that they hardly notice they were led.

PRACTICE

Find one task you would normally direct or do for someone else at work or at home. Instead, give them the goal and the tools, then step back. When it is done, let the credit stay entirely with them.

KEY LINE

Their work was done and their undertakings
were successful, while the people all
said, 'We are as we are, of ourselves!'

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 18

1 When the Great Tao (Way or Method) ceased to be observed, benevolence and righteousness came into vogue. (Then) appeared wisdom and shrewdness, and there ensued great hypocrisy.

2 When harmony no longer prevailed throughout the six kinships, filial sons found their manifestation; when the states and clans fell into disorder, loyal ministers appeared.

REFLECTION

This short chapter makes a sharp observation. When the great Way was lost, people started talking about benevolence and righteousness. When cleverness appeared, so did large-scale hypocrisy. When families fell apart, "dutiful children" were praised. When nations fell into chaos, "loyal ministers" became famous. The point is that we name and celebrate virtues most loudly when they have become rare. This was partly a jab at the Confucian teachers of the day, who stressed these very virtues. A modern reader may recognize the pattern in mission statements and slogans. A workplace that constantly preaches trust may lack it. Real goodness tends to be quiet and ordinary.

PRACTICE

Look at a value you often talk about, such as honesty, patience, or kindness. Today, practice it once without naming it, explaining it, or pointing it out. Let the action speak for itself.

KEY LINE

When the Great Tao (Way or Method) ceased to be observed, benevolence and righteousness came into vogue.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 19

1 If we could renounce our sageness and discard our wisdom, it would be better for the people a hundredfold. If we could renounce our benevolence and discard our righteousness, the people would again become filial and kindly. If we could renounce our artful contrivances and discard our (scheming for) gain, there would be no thieves nor robbers.

2 *Those three methods (of government)*
Thought olden ways in elegance did fail
And made these names their want of worth to veil;
But simple views, and courses plain and true
Would selfish ends and many lusts eschew.

REFLECTION

This chapter pushes the previous one further. Give up showy wisdom, and people will be far better off. Give up preaching kindness and duty, and people will naturally care for their families again. Give up clever tricks and the chase for profit, and thieves will disappear. Lao Tzu, as tradition calls the author, is not against goodness. He is against goodness turned into rules, slogans, and performance. The verse ends with the remedy: simple views, plain and honest ways, fewer selfish aims, and fewer cravings. For us, it can mean dropping the elaborate systems we build to look good and returning to straightforward decency. Simplicity is often the cleaner path to what we were trying to fake.

PRACTICE

Choose one area where you have built complicated rules for yourself, such as productivity, diet, or self-improvement. Replace it today with one plain sentence of intent, like “Be kind” or “Eat when hungry.” Live by that line alone.

KEY LINE

But simple views, and courses plain and true

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 20

1 *When we renounce learning we have no troubles.*
The (ready) 'yes,' and (flattering) 'yea;'—
Small is the difference they display.
But mark their issues, good and ill;—
What space the gulf between shall fill?

WHAT ALL men fear is indeed to be feared; but how wide and without end is the range of questions (asking to be discussed)!

2 The multitude of men look satisfied and pleased; as if enjoying a full banquet, as if mounted on a tower in spring. I alone seem listless and still, my desires having as yet given no indication of their presence. I am like an infant which has not yet smiled. I look dejected and forlorn, as if I had no home to go to. The multitude of men all have enough and to spare. I alone seem to have lost everything. My mind is that of a stupid man; I am in a state of chaos.

Ordinary men look bright and intelligent, while I alone seem to be benighted. They look full of discrimination, while I alone am dull and confused. I seem to be carried about as on the sea, drifting as if I had nowhere to rest. All men have their spheres of action, while I alone seem dull and incapable, like a rude borderer. (Thus) I alone am different from other men, but I value the nursing-mother (the Tao).

REFLECTION

This is the most personal chapter in the book. The speaker contrasts himself with the crowd. Everyone else seems cheerful, busy, and sure, as if at a feast or climbing a tower in spring. He alone feels quiet, aimless, like a baby that has not yet smiled, like someone with no home to go to. Others seem bright; he seems dim. Others have plenty; he seems to have nothing. It reads almost like loneliness, yet it ends in quiet strength: he is different because he is nourished by the Mother, the Tao. For anyone who has felt out of step with a busy, confident world, this chapter offers company. Being different is not being lost.

PRACTICE

Spend fifteen minutes today doing nothing productive: sit, walk slowly, or look out a window. If you feel guilt or the pull to be busy like everyone else, notice it kindly. Then let yourself simply be fed by the quiet.

KEY LINE

(Thus) I alone am different from other men,
but I value the nursing-mother (the Tao).

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 21

The grandest forms of active force
From Tao come, their only source.
Who can of Tao the nature tell?
Our sight it flies, our touch as well.
Eluding sight, eluding touch,
The forms of things all in it crouch;
Eluding touch, eluding sight,
There are their semblances, all right.
Profound it is, dark and obscure;
Things' essences all there endure.
Those essences the truth enfold
Of what, when seen, shall then be told.
Now it is so; 'twas so of old.
Its name—what passes not away;
So, in their beautiful array,
Things form and never know decay.

HOW KNOW I that it is so with all the beauties of existing things? By this (nature of the Tao).

REFLECTION

In a long rhymed passage, the chapter describes how all real power and all forms come from the Tao. The Tao itself escapes sight and touch, dim and

deep, yet inside it lie the patterns of things, their essences, and their truth. It has been this way from the beginning and stays so now. Its name never passes away, and because of it things keep taking shape in their beautiful order. The chapter ends by asking how we know this, and answers: by this very nature of the Tao. For a modern reader, the chapter is a quiet wonder at how much order and beauty arise from what we cannot see or fully explain.

PRACTICE

Look closely at one natural pattern today: the veins of a leaf, frost on glass, the spiral of a shell, the grain in wood. Study it for two minutes. Let yourself wonder where its order comes from without needing an answer.

KEY LINE

Things' essences all there endure.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 22

1 The partial becomes complete; the crooked, straight; the empty, full; the worn out, new. He whose (desires) are few gets them; he whose (desires) are many goes astray.

2 Therefore the sage holds in his embrace the one thing (of humility), and manifests it to all the world. He is free from self-display, and therefore he shines; from self-assertion, and therefore he is distinguished; from self-boasting, and therefore his merit is acknowledged; from self-complacency, and therefore he acquires superiority. It is because he is thus free from striving that therefore no one in the world is able to strive with him.

3 That saying of the ancients that 'the partial becomes complete' was not vainly spoken:—all real completion is comprehended under it.

REFLECTION

Bend and you become whole. Be crooked and you become straight. Be empty and you will be filled. Wear out and you will be renewed. Want little and you get it; want much and you get lost. These paradoxes describe how life often works when we stop forcing it. The sage holds to this, and so he shines without showing off, gets noticed without pushing, and earns credit without bragging. Because he does not compete, no one can compete with him. In a world that tells us to brand and promote ourselves, this sounds backward. Yet most of us trust and admire the people who do not need to prove anything.

PRACTICE

In a conversation today, resist the urge to share your own achievement or win the argument. Let someone else have the last word. Afterward, notice whether you lost anything real, or just the itch to be seen.

KEY LINE

It is because he is thus free from striving that
therefore no one in the world is able to strive with him.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 23

1 Abstaining from speech marks him who is obeying the spontaneity of his nature. A violent wind does not last for a whole morning; a sudden rain does not last for the whole day. To whom is it that these (two) things are owing? To Heaven and Earth. If Heaven and Earth cannot make such (spasmodic) actings last long, how much less can man!

2 Therefore when one is making the Tao his business, those who are also pursuing it, agree with him in it, and those who are making the manifestation of its course their object agree with him in that; while even those who are failing in both these things agree with him where they fail.

3 Hence, those with whom he agrees as to the Tao have the happiness of attaining to it; those with whom he agrees as to its manifestation have the happiness of attaining to it; and those with whom he agrees in their failure have also the happiness of attaining (to the Tao). (But) when there is not faith sufficient (on his part), a want of faith (in him) ensues (on the part of the others).

REFLECTION

Speaking little is natural. A violent wind does not last all morning, and a sudden downpour does not last all day. If even heaven and earth cannot keep up such outbursts, how could we? The rest of the chapter, though tangled in Legge's English, says that we become one with what we follow. Walk with the Way and you join the Way. Walk with virtue and you join virtue. Even in failure, you join

what you have chosen. It closes with a line about trust: if you do not trust enough, you will not be trusted. Today, this is a reminder that storms of anger or panic pass, and that what we keep company with shapes us.

PRACTICE

The next time you feel a strong emotion rise, such as anger, panic, or frustration, think "this is weather." Wait it out for two minutes before acting or speaking. Notice how the storm changes on its own.

KEY LINE

A violent wind does not last for a whole morning;
a sudden rain does not last for the whole day.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 24

He who stands on his tiptoes does not stand firm; he who stretches his legs does not walk (easily). (So), he who displays himself does not shine; he who asserts his own views is not distinguished; he who vaunts himself does not find his merit acknowledged; he who is self-conceited has no superiority allowed to him. Such conditions, viewed from the standpoint of the Tao, are like remnants of food, or a tumour on the body, which all dislike. Hence those who pursue (the course) of the Tao do not adopt and allow them.

REFLECTION

If you stand on tiptoe, you lose your balance. If you take giant strides, you cannot walk far. In the same way, people who show off do not shine, people who insist on their opinions do not stand out, and people who brag do not get the credit they want. From the view of the Way, these habits are like leftover food or a growth on the body: unpleasant and useless. Those who follow the Way avoid them. The image is easy to remember. Straining to look taller, smarter, or more important makes us unsteady. Standing on your whole foot, at your natural size, is both more comfortable and more convincing.

PRACTICE

Stand barefoot for one minute with your weight spread evenly over both feet. Then rise onto tiptoe and notice the wobble. Settle back down. Today,

whenever you feel the urge to impress someone, remember that feeling of settling.

KEY LINE

He who stands on his tiptoes does not stand firm;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 25

1 There was something undefined and complete, coming into existence before Heaven and Earth. How still it was and formless, standing alone, and undergoing no change, reaching everywhere and in no danger (of being exhausted)! It may be regarded as the Mother of all things.

2 I do not know its name, and I give it the designation of the Tao (the Way or Course). Making an effort (further) to give it a name I call it The Great.

3 Great, it passes on (in constant flow). Passing on, it becomes remote. Having become remote, it returns. Therefore the Tao is great; Heaven is great; Earth is great; and the (sage) king is also great. In the universe there are four that are great, and the (sage) king is one of them.

4 Man takes his law from the Earth; the Earth takes its law from Heaven; Heaven takes its law from the Tao. The law of the Tao is its being what it is.

REFLECTION

Before heaven and earth, there was something formless and complete, silent and alone, unchanging, reaching everywhere. It is like the mother of the world. The author admits he does not know its name, so he calls it Tao, "the Way," and if pushed, "the Great." Greatness flows outward, travels far, and returns. Four things are great: the Way, heaven, earth, and the wise ruler. The final line gives a ladder: people follow the earth, earth follows heaven, heaven follows the

Way, and the Way simply follows its own nature. For modern life, this is an invitation to take cues from the natural world and, at the deepest level, to let things be what they are.

PRACTICE

Spend ten minutes outdoors, ideally on soil or grass, and simply notice how the ground supports you, the sky holds the weather, and everything moves at its own pace. Ask yourself: what in my life would go better if I let it be what it is?

KEY LINE

The law of the Tao is its being what it is.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 26

1 Gravity is the root of lightness; stillness, the ruler of movement.

2 Therefore a wise prince, marching the whole day, does not go far from his baggage waggons. Although he may have brilliant prospects to look at, he quietly remains (in his proper place), indifferent to them. How should the lord of a myriad chariots carry himself lightly before the kingdom? If he do act lightly, he has lost his root (of gravity); if he proceed to active movement, he will lose his throne.

REFLECTION

Heaviness is the root of lightness, and stillness is the master of restlessness. The chapter uses the image of a wise prince who travels all day without leaving his supply wagons behind. However exciting the scenery, he stays calm and grounded. A ruler of a great state should never act carelessly, because acting lightly costs him his roots, and restless action costs him his position. The language is ancient, but the advice is familiar. Excitement, new opportunities, and constant motion can pull us away from what supports us. Staying near your "baggage," meaning your values, your health, and the people who rely on you, keeps you steady when things move fast.

PRACTICE

Write down three things that are your "baggage wagons," the steady supports of your life. Before making any quick decision today, glance at the list and ask whether the choice keeps you close to them or pulls you away.

KEY LINE

Gravity is the root of lightness;
stillness, the ruler of movement.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 27

1 The skilful traveller leaves no traces of his wheels or footsteps; the skilful speaker says nothing that can be found fault with or blamed; the skilful reckoner uses no tallies; the skilful closer needs no bolts or bars, while to open what he has shut will be impossible; the skilful binder uses no strings or knots, while to unloose what he has bound will be impossible. In the same way the sage is always skilful at saving men, and so he does not cast away any man; he is always skilful at saving things, and so he does not cast away anything. This is called 'Hiding the light of his procedure.'

2 Therefore the man of skill is a master (to be looked up to) by him who has not the skill; and he who has not the skill is the helper of (the reputation of) him who has the skill. If the one did not honour his master, and the other did not rejoice in his helper, an (observer), though intelligent, might greatly err about them. This is called 'The utmost degree of mystery.'

REFLECTION

A skilled traveler leaves no tracks. A skilled speaker makes no slips. A skilled counter needs no tally sticks. A skilled door-closer needs no bolts, yet no one can open what he shuts. Real mastery looks effortless. The sage, too, is good at saving people and things, and so he throws nothing and no one away. Legge calls this hiding the light of his method. The good person teaches the struggling one, and the struggling one gives the good person a reason to teach. Each

needs the other. For today, the chapter suggests a generous view: no one is useless, and the person who frustrates you may be your best teacher, or your best student.

PRACTICE

Think of one person you have quietly written off. Today, find one way to include them: ask their opinion, offer help, or thank them for something specific. Notice what this shows you about them and about yourself.

KEY LINE

In the same way the sage is always skilful at
saving men, and so he does not cast away any man;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 28

1 *Who knows his manhood's strength,*
Yet still his female feebleness maintains;
As to one channel flow the many drains,
All come to him, yea, all beneath the sky.
Thus he the constant excellence retains;
The simple child again, free from all stains.

Who knows how white attracts,
Yet always keeps himself within black's shade,
The pattern of humility displayed,
Displayed in view of all beneath the sky;
He in the unchanging excellence arrayed,
Endless return to man's first state has made.

Who knows how glory shines,
Yet loves disgrace, nor e'er for it is pale;
Behold his presence in a spacious vale,
To which men come from all beneath the sky.
The unchanging excellence completes its tale;
The simple infant man in him we hail.

2 The unwrought material, when divided and distributed, forms vessels. The sage, when employed, becomes the Head of all the Officers (of government); and in his greatest regulations he employs no violent measures.

REFLECTION

This chapter asks you to know your strength and still choose the lower, softer place. Know the bright and stay near the shade; know honor and stay at ease with being overlooked. Legge's rhymes make it sound grand, but the idea is simple: the person who does not need to be on top becomes a place others flow toward, the way small streams run into one channel. The closing image is "the unwrought material," the uncarved block. Raw wood can become many vessels, but it holds every possibility only while it is uncut. Today this might mean keeping some part of yourself unlabeled and unfinished: not every skill needs to be displayed, and not every role needs to define you.

PRACTICE

In one conversation today, hold back a point you know would make you look clever. Let someone else have the last word. Afterward, notice whether anything was actually lost.

KEY LINE

The unwrought material, when
divided and distributed, forms vessels.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 29

1 If any one should wish to get the kingdom for himself, and to effect this by what he does, I see that he will not succeed. The kingdom is a spirit-like thing, and cannot be got by active doing. He who would so win it destroys it; he who would hold it in his grasp loses it.

2 *The course and nature of things is such that*
What was in front is now behind;
What warmed anon we freezing find.
Strength is of weakness oft the spoil;
The store in ruins mocks our toil.

HENCE THE sage puts away excessive effort, extravagance, and easy indulgence.

REFLECTION

You cannot grab the world and make it behave. Legge calls the kingdom "a spirit-like thing": something alive, which slips away from a clenched fist. Whoever tries to seize it damages it, and whoever clutches it loses it. The rhymed middle reminds us that everything turns: what was in front falls behind, warmth gives way to cold, strength becomes weakness. So the sage drops three habits: excessive effort, extravagance, and easy indulgence. For a modern reader this applies well beyond politics. A team, a child, a relationship, even your own mood, will resist being forced into shape. Care and attention work better than control, because the thing you are tending has a life of its own.

PRACTICE

Pick one situation you have been trying to control: a project, a person, a plan. For one day, do only what is clearly needed and stop there. Write down what happened without your extra pushing.

KEY LINE

He who would so win it destroys it; he who would hold it in his grasp loses it.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 30

1 He who would assist a lord of men in harmony with the Tao will not assert his mastery in the kingdom by force of arms. Such a course is sure to meet with its proper return.

2 Wherever a host is stationed, briars and thorns spring up. In the sequence of great armies there are sure to be bad years.

3 A skilful (commander) strikes a decisive blow, and stops. He does not dare (by continuing his operations) to assert and complete his mastery. He will strike the blow, but will be on his guard against being vain or boastful or arrogant in consequence of it. He strikes it as a matter of necessity; he strikes it, but not from a wish for mastery.

4 When things have attained their strong maturity they become old. This may be said to be not in accordance with the Tao: and what is not in accordance with it soon comes to an end.

REFLECTION

This is advice to someone who serves a ruler: do not build power on armies. Wherever troops camp, thorns grow; after great wars come bad harvests. If force truly cannot be avoided, strike once, then stop, and do not boast about it. The chapter was written in an age of constant warfare between Chinese states, and it reads as a sober warning, not a celebration of the clever commander. Its last verse widens the point: things pushed to their peak quickly grow old and end. Today you can hear it in any contest of wills. Win what must be won, then

let it go. Pressing an advantage until the other side is crushed tends to come back to you.

PRACTICE

The next time you win an argument or a negotiation, stop as soon as the real issue is settled. Do not add a final remark or a told-you-so. Watch how the other person responds.

KEY LINE

A skilful (commander) strikes a decisive blow, and stops.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 31

1 Now arms, however beautiful, are instruments of evil omen, hateful, it may be said, to all creatures. Therefore they who have the Tao do not like to employ them.

2 The superior man ordinarily considers the left hand the most honourable place, but in time of war the right hand. Those sharp weapons are instruments of evil omen, and not the instruments of the superior man;—he uses them only on the compulsion of necessity. Calm and repose are what he prizes; victory (by force of arms) is to him undesirable. To consider this desirable would be to delight in the slaughter of men; and he who delights in the slaughter of men cannot get his will in the kingdom.

3 On occasions of festivity to be on the left hand is the prized position; on occasions of mourning, the right hand. The second in command of the army has his place on the left; the general commanding in chief has his on the right;—his place, that is, is assigned to him as in the rites of mourning. He who has killed multitudes of men should weep for them with the bitterest grief; and the victor in battle has his place (rightly) according to those rites.

REFLECTION

Weapons, however beautiful, are "instruments of evil omen." The person of the Tao does not like to use them, and uses them only when there is no other

choice. The chapter draws on old Chinese ritual: the left was the place of honor at feasts, the right the place of mourning, and the general stands on the right, as if at a funeral. Even a victory should be marked with grief for the dead. This is not pacifism in the modern sense; the text accepts that force is sometimes necessary. But it refuses to glorify it. A modern reader might hear it as a call to treat any use of force, in a nation or in a home, as a sad necessity and never as a triumph.

PRACTICE

Notice today one place where you treat someone else's loss as your win: in sport, at work, online. Pause and name, silently, what it cost the other side.

KEY LINE

Calm and repose are what he prizes; victory
(by force of arms) is to him undesirable.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 32

1 The Tao, considered as unchanging, has no name.

2 Though in its primordial simplicity it may be small, the whole world dares not deal with (one embodying) it as a minister. If a feudal prince or the king could guard and hold it, all would spontaneously submit themselves to him.

3 Heaven and Earth (under its guidance) unite together and send down the sweet dew, which, without the directions of men, reaches equally everywhere as of its own accord.

4 As soon as it proceeds to action, it has a name. When it once has that name, (men) can know to rest in it. When they know to rest in it, they can be free from all risk of failure and error.

5 The relation of the Tao to all the world is like that of the great rivers and seas to the streams from the valleys.

REFLECTION

The Tao, in its unchanging nature, has no name. It looks small, like an uncarved block, yet nothing in the world can make it a servant. If rulers could hold to it, people would settle of their own accord, the way sweet dew falls evenly on every field without anyone directing it. Then the chapter turns: once things begin, names arise, and wisdom lies in knowing where to rest within them, when to stop dividing and defining. The final image is of streams in the valleys

running into rivers and seas. Everything finds its way home. Today this can mean trusting that some things balance themselves when we stop managing every detail, and knowing when we have labeled enough.

PRACTICE

Sit for three minutes and let sounds, thoughts, and sensations come without naming them. When a label arises (“traffic,” “worry,” “itch”), notice it and let it go, as if returning water to a river.

KEY LINE

The relation of the Tao to all the world is like that of the great rivers and seas to the streams from the valleys.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 33

1 He who knows other men is discerning; he who knows himself is intelligent. He who overcomes others is strong; he who overcomes himself is mighty. He who is satisfied with his lot is rich; he who goes on acting with energy has a (firm) will.

2 He who does not fail in the requirements of his position, continues long; he who dies and yet does not perish, has longevity.

REFLECTION

Six short contrasts make this one of the clearest chapters in the book. Knowing others is clever; knowing yourself is wisdom. Defeating others is strength; mastering yourself is real power. Being content with what you have is wealth. Steady effort shows a firm will. Then come two lines about lasting: staying true to your place lets you endure, and the one who dies yet does not perish has true long life. That last line is best read as an image, not a promise: what we have been and given does not simply vanish. The chapter turns attention inward. Most of us spend far more energy studying other people than understanding ourselves, and this is a quiet invitation to reverse the balance.

PRACTICE

Tonight write one sentence about someone else that irritated you today. Under it, write one honest sentence about what that irritation might be showing you about yourself and your own needs.

KEY LINE

He who knows other men is discerning;
he who knows himself is intelligent.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 34

1 All-pervading is the Great Tao! It may be found on the left hand and on the right.

2 All things depend on it for their production, which it gives to them, not one refusing obedience to it. When its work is accomplished, it does not claim the name of having done it. It clothes all things as with a garment, and makes no assumption of being their lord;—it may be named in the smallest things. All things return (to their root and disappear), and do not know that it is it which presides over their doing so;—it may be named in the greatest things.

3 Hence the sage is able (in the same way) to accomplish his great achievements. It is through his not making himself great that he can accomplish them.

REFLECTION

The Great Tao flows everywhere, to the left and to the right. Everything depends on it, yet it claims nothing. It clothes all things like a garment but does not act as their lord. Because it asks for nothing, it can be called small; because everything returns to it, it can be called great. The sage works the same way: he achieves great things precisely because he does not try to make himself great. In everyday terms, this is the quiet support of a good parent, teacher, or colleague who makes others succeed without needing credit. The most important work is often invisible, and the people doing it are rarely the loudest in the room.

PRACTICE

Do one helpful thing today without letting anyone know it was you: refill something, fix something, smooth a path. Resist the urge to mention it later.

KEY LINE

It is through his not making himself great that he can accomplish them.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 35

1 To him who holds in his hands the Great Image (of the invisible Tao), the whole world repairs. Men resort to him, and receive no hurt, but (find) rest, peace, and the feeling of ease.

2 Music and dainties will make the passing guest stop (for a time). But though the Tao as it comes from the mouth, seems insipid and has no flavour, though it seems not worth being looked at or listened to, the use of it is inexhaustible.

REFLECTION

Whoever holds the "Great Image," the shape of the Tao, becomes someone others come to, and they find rest, peace, and ease there rather than harm. Then a striking contrast: music and fine food make a traveler stop for a while, but the Tao, when spoken about, seems bland. It has no flavor, looks unremarkable, and sounds like nothing special. Yet its use never runs out. This is a fair warning for a modern reader surrounded by stimulation. The things that truly sustain us, such as sleep, plain food, honest friendship, and quiet, rarely feel exciting. Their value shows up over years, not moments.

PRACTICE

Choose one plain thing today, a glass of water, a walk with no headphones, a slow meal, and give it your full attention. Notice whether "boring" turns into something calmer.

KEY LINE

Music and dainties will make the passing guest stop (for a time).

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 36

1 When one is about to take an inspiration, he is sure to make a (previous) expiration; when he is going to weaken another, he will first strengthen him; when he is going to overthrow another, he will first have raised him up; when he is going to despoil another, he will first have made gifts to him:—this is called 'Hiding the light (of his procedure).'

2 The soft overcomes the hard; and the weak the strong.

3 Fishes should not be taken from the deep; instruments for the profit of a state should not be shown to the people.

REFLECTION

This chapter can sound like a manual for cunning: to weaken something, first strengthen it; to bring it down, first raise it up. Many readers take it instead as an observation of how things move. A breath out comes before a breath in, and what swells to its fullest is about to shrink. Seen that way, it is a warning about the moment of peak success. Then comes one of the book's central lines: the soft overcomes the hard. The last verse, about fish staying in the deep and a state's sharp tools not being displayed, reflects an old view of rulership that kept power hidden. Today we value openness in government, but the image still warns against showing off one's strength.

PRACTICE

When something in your life is going unusually well, write down one way it could overreach. Choose one small step today to keep it modest and steady.

KEY LINE

The soft overcomes the hard; and the weak the strong.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 37

1 The Tao in its regular course does nothing (for the sake of doing it), and so there is nothing which it does not do.

2 If princes and kings were able to maintain it, all things would of themselves be transformed by them.

3 If this transformation became to me an object of desire, I would express the desire by the nameless simplicity.

Simplicity without a name
Is free from all external aim.
With no desire, at rest and still,
All things go right as of their will.

REFLECTION

Here is the heart of wu wei in one sentence: the Tao does nothing, yet nothing is left undone. It does not force or fuss, and still everything grows. If rulers could hold to this, the world would change of its own accord. And if, along the way, desire to control those changes rose up, the answer would be "the nameless simplicity," the uncarved block again. The closing rhyme sums it up: without grasping, at rest and still, things find their own right course. In modern life this is not laziness. It is the gardener's patience, the teacher's restraint, the leader who sets conditions well and then steps back.

PRACTICE

Choose one task where you usually hover: checking a message thread, tweaking a draft, supervising someone. Set it up well once, then leave it alone for a full day.

KEY LINE

The Tao in its regular course does nothing (for the sake of doing it), and so there is nothing which it does not do.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 38

1 (Those who) possessed in highest degree the attributes (of the Tao) did not (seek) to show them, and therefore they possessed them (in fullest measure). (Those who) possessed in a lower degree those attributes (sought how) not to lose them, and therefore they did not possess them (in fullest measure).

2 (Those who) possessed in the highest degree those attributes did nothing (with a purpose), and had no need to do anything. (Those who) possessed them in a lower degree were (always) doing, and had need to be so doing.

3 (Those who) possessed the highest benevolence were (always seeking) to carry it out, and had no need to be doing so. (Those who) possessed the highest righteousness were (always seeking) to carry it out, and had need to be so doing.

4 (Those who) possessed the highest (sense of) propriety were (always seeking) to show it, and when men did not respond to it, they bared the arm and marched up to them.

5 Thus it was that when the Tao was lost, its attributes appeared; when its attributes were lost, benevolence appeared; when benevolence was lost, righteousness appeared; and when righteousness was lost, the proprieties appeared.

6 Now propriety is the attenuated form of leal-heartedness and good faith, and is also the commencement of disorder; swift apprehension is (only) a flower of the Tao, and is the beginning of stupidity.

7 Thus it is that the Great man abides by what is solid, and eschews what is flimsy; dwells with the fruit and not with the flower. It is thus that he puts away the one and makes choice of the other.

✦

REFLECTION

This chapter opens the second part of the book, the part on Te, or virtue. Real virtue, it says, does not display itself, and so it is real. Lesser virtue is anxious not to lose itself, and so it is thin. Then comes a sharp line of decline: when the Tao is lost, virtue appears; when virtue is lost, kindness; then justice; then rules of propriety. When people do not respond to those rules, they roll up their sleeves and force them. This is aimed partly at the Confucian emphasis on ritual. Today we can read it as a warning about organizations and relationships that pile up policies once trust has gone. The image to keep is fruit, not flower: substance over show.

PRACTICE

Look at one rule you enforce at home or at work. Ask: what was the trust this rule replaced? Find one small way today to rebuild that trust directly.

KEY LINE

dwells with the fruit and not with the flower.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 39

1 The things which from of old have got the One (the Tao) are—

Heaven which by it is bright and pure;
Earth rendered thereby firm and sure;
Spirits with powers by it supplied;
Valleys kept full throughout their void
All creatures which through it do live
Princes and kings who from it get
The model which to all they give.

ALL THESE are the results of the One (Tao).

2 *If heaven were not thus pure, it soon would rend;*
If earth were not thus sure, 'twould break and bend;
Without these powers, the spirits soon would fail;
If not so filled, the drought would parch each vale;
Without that life, creatures would pass away;
Princes and kings, without that moral sway,
However grand and high, would all decay.

3 Thus it is that dignity finds its (firm) root in its (previous) meanness, and what is lofty finds its stability in the lowness (from which it rises). Hence princes and kings call themselves 'Orphans,' 'Men of small virtue,' and as 'Carriages without a nave.' Is not this an acknowledgment that in their considering themselves mean they see the foundation of their dignity? So it is that in the enumeration of the different parts of a carriage we do not come on what makes it answer the ends of a carriage.

They do not wish to show themselves elegant-looking as jade, but (prefer) to be coarse-looking as an (ordinary) stone.

✦

REFLECTION

Everything that holds together does so by getting "the One": heaven becomes clear, earth steady, valleys full, living things alive. Lose it, and each would crack, dry up, or fade. Then the chapter turns to rulers. High rank rests on what is low, the way a tall building rests on its foundation. That is why old Chinese kings humbly called themselves "orphans" and "men of small virtue." The book's own image is a carriage: count its parts and you never find the "carriage" itself. The closing line is lovely: do not try to shine like jade; be content as plain stone. Today it reminds us that status grows out of the ordinary people and plain work beneath it.

PRACTICE

Write down three people whose unnoticed work keeps your daily life running. Thank one of them today, simply and specifically, naming exactly what they do and how it helps you.

KEY LINE

They do not wish to show themselves
elegant-looking as jade, but (prefer) to
be coarse-looking as an (ordinary) stone.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 40

1 *The movement of the Tao*
By contraries proceeds;
And weakness marks the course
Of Tao's mighty deeds.

2 All things under heaven sprang from It as existing (and named); that existence sprang from It as non-existent (and not named).

REFLECTION

The shortest chapter in this stretch is also one of the deepest. The Tao moves by return, by turning back; its strength works through weakness. Everything that exists came from being, and being came from non-being. Legge puts it in a small rhyme: the movement of the Tao proceeds by contraries. In plain words, life swings: day to night, effort to rest, growth to decay and back again. Instead of fighting that rhythm, we can learn to ride it. The idea of something coming out of nothing may sound abstract, but think of silence before music, or a blank page before a letter. Emptiness is where things begin.

PRACTICE

Before your next important task, sit for one minute in silence with your hands empty. Let the task begin from that stillness rather than from a rush.

KEY LINE

And weakness marks the course Of Tao's mighty deeds.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 41

1 Scholars of the highest class, when they hear about the Tao, earnestly carry it into practice. Scholars of the middle class, when they have heard about it, seem now to keep it and now to lose it. Scholars of the lowest class, when they have heard about it, laugh greatly at it. If it were not (thus) laughed at, it would not be fit to be the Tao.

2 Therefore the sentence-makers have thus expressed themselves:—

'The Tao, when brightest seen, seems light to lack;
Who progress in it makes, seems drawing back;
Its even way is like a rugged track.
Its highest virtue from the vale doth rise;
Its greatest beauty seems to offend the eyes;
And he has most whose lot the least supplies.
Its firmest virtue seems but poor and low;
Its solid truth seems change to undergo;
Its largest square doth yet no corner show
A vessel great, it is the slowest made;
Loud is its sound, but never word it said;
A semblance great, the shadow of a shade.'

3 The Tao is hidden, and has no name; but it is the Tao which is skilful at imparting (to all things what they need) and making them complete.

REFLECTION

When the best students hear of the Tao, they practice it. Average students half believe it. The worst laugh out loud, and if they did not laugh, it would not be the Tao. Then comes a string of paradoxes: the bright way looks dim, moving forward looks like going back, the highest virtue is low as a valley, great talent matures slowly, the great sound is barely heard. The Chinese words behind "a vessel great, it is the slowest made" became a common proverb for late bloomers. Today it is comfort for anyone who feels behind. Real depth takes time, often looks unimpressive from outside, and may even draw mockery along the way.

PRACTICE

Name one skill or quality you are slowly building. Write a note to yourself: "Slow is not failing." Put it where you will see it this week.

KEY LINE

A vessel great, it is the slowest made;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 42

1 The Tao produced One; One produced Two; Two produced Three; Three produced All things. All things leave behind them the Obscurity (out of which they have come), and go forward to embrace the Brightness (into which they have emerged), while they are harmonised by the Breath of Vacancy.

2 What men dislike is to be orphans, to have little virtue, to be as carriages without naves; and yet these are the designations which kings and princes use for themselves. So it is that some things are increased by being diminished, and others are diminished by being increased.

3 What other men (thus) teach, I also teach. The violent and strong do not die their natural death. I will make this the basis of my teaching.

REFLECTION

The Tao gives birth to one, one to two, two to three, and three to all things. Many readers see in "two" the paired forces later called yin and yang, held in balance by a blending breath. Then the chapter returns to humility: rulers call themselves by the very names people dislike, "orphan," "small in virtue." Things grow by being reduced and shrink by being swollen. The chapter ends with a teaching the author says he shares with others: the violent and overbearing do not die a natural death. This is less a threat than an observation. Hardness invites resistance. A life built on force tends to meet force in return.

PRACTICE

The next time you feel the urge to push hard against someone, take three slow breaths first. Then ask what the softest effective step would be.

KEY LINE

So it is that some things are increased by being diminished, and others are diminished by being increased.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 43

1 The softest thing in the world dashes against and overcomes the hardest; that which has no (substantial) existence enters where there is no crevice. I know hereby what advantage belongs to doing nothing (with a purpose).

2 There are few in the world who attain to the teaching without words, and the advantage arising from non-action.

REFLECTION

The softest thing in the world overcomes the hardest. That which has no solid form enters where there is no gap at all. Think of water seeping into stone, or air filling a sealed room. From this the author learns the value of not forcing. He adds that few people ever grasp two things: teaching without words, and the benefit of acting without strain. For us, the image is useful in conflict and in learning. A gentle, steady presence often reaches people that lectures cannot. And the example we set, without saying anything, may be the clearest lesson we ever give.

PRACTICE

Today, try to teach or encourage someone without explaining. Show it by doing it: tidy calmly, listen fully, keep a promise. Let your action do the talking.

KEY LINE

The softest thing in the world dashes
against and overcomes the hardest;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 44

1 *Or fame or life,*
Which do you hold more dear?
Or life or wealth,
To which would you adhere?
Keep life and lose those other things;
Keep them and lose your life:—which brings
Sorrow and pain more near?

2 *Thus we may see,*
Who cleaves to fame
Rejects what is more great;
Who loves large stores
Gives up the richer state.

3 *Who is content*
Needs fear no shame.
Who knows to stop
Incurs no blame.
From danger free
Long live shall he.

REFLECTION

Legge turns this chapter into a little song of questions. Fame or your life: which is dearer? Your life or your wealth: which matters more? Gaining or losing:

which actually hurts? Whoever clings to fame pays heavily; whoever hoards much loses much. The answer comes at the end: know what is enough and you will not be shamed; know when to stop and you will not be harmed. "Long live shall he" is best read as a picture of a life kept whole, not as a promise about years. In a culture that measures worth by followers and income, these questions are as sharp as ever. Enough is a decision, not a number.

PRACTICE

Write down one thing you are chasing right now. Next to it, write what "enough" would honestly look like. Circle the point at which you would stop.

KEY LINE

Who is content Needs fear no shame.
Who knows to stop Incurs no blame.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 45

1 *Who thinks his great achievements poor*
Shall find his vigour long endure.
Of greatest fulness, deemed a void,
Exhaustion ne'er shall stem the tide.
Do thou what's straight still crooked deem;
Thy greatest art still stupid seem,
And eloquence a stammering scream.

2 Constant action overcomes cold; being still overcomes heat. Purity and stillness give the correct law to all under heaven.

REFLECTION

Great achievement looks unfinished, yet it does not wear out. Great fullness looks empty, yet it never runs dry. The straightest seems crooked, the greatest skill seems clumsy, the finest speech sounds halting. The chapter is a gentle warning against judging by surfaces. Then two simple lines: movement overcomes cold, and stillness overcomes heat. Clarity and calm set things right in the world. Today we might apply this in two ways. First, do not rush to polish everything; work that leaves room keeps its life. Second, when heated by anger or stress, reach first for stillness, not more activity.

PRACTICE

When you next feel heated, stop moving for sixty seconds. Sit, put both feet on the floor, and let your breath slow before you speak or type anything.

KEY LINE

Constant action overcomes cold; being still overcomes heat.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 46

1 When the Tao prevails in the world, they send back their swift horses to (draw) the dung-carts. When the Tao is disregarded in the world, the war-horses breed in the border lands.

2 There is no guilt greater than to sanction ambition; no calamity greater than to be discontented with one's lot; no fault greater than the wish to be getting. Therefore the sufficiency of contentment is an enduring and unchanging sufficiency.

REFLECTION

When the Tao is present in the world, fast horses are sent back to haul manure on the farms. When it is absent, warhorses are bred on the frontier. The picture is vivid: peace puts strength to humble, useful work, while lack of peace turns it toward conflict. Then the root cause: there is no greater calamity than not knowing what is enough, and no greater fault than wanting to get more. The chapter ends with a quiet, powerful idea. The contentment of knowing "this is enough" is the only enough that lasts. Every other kind runs out and asks for more.

PRACTICE

Before you buy anything nonessential today, wait one hour and ask: "Will this make what I already have feel like enough?" Note your answer, whatever you decide.

KEY LINE

Therefore the sufficiency of contentment is an enduring and unchanging sufficiency.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 47

1 Without going outside his door, one understands (all that takes place) under the sky; without looking out from his window, one sees the Tao of Heaven. The farther that one goes out (from himself), the less he knows.

2 Therefore the sages got their knowledge without travelling; gave their (right) names to things without seeing them; and accomplished their ends without any purpose of doing so.

REFLECTION

Without going out of your door, you can know the world. Without looking through your window, you can see the way of heaven. The farther you go, the less you know. This sounds odd in an age of travel and endless information, but the point is not that learning is useless. It is that the most important understanding comes from looking inward and noticing what is near. Running after more input can leave us scattered. The sage understands without wandering and accomplishes without straining. For a busy modern reader, this chapter is permission to stay home in your own attention for a while.

PRACTICE

Spend fifteen minutes today with no screen, no book, no outside input. Sit by a window or a door and simply observe what you already know about your life right now.

KEY LINE

The farther that one goes out
(from himself), the less he knows.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 48

1 He who devotes himself to learning (seeks) from day to day to increase (his knowledge); he who devotes himself to the Tao (seeks) from day to day to diminish (his doing).

2 He diminishes it and again diminishes it, till he arrives at doing nothing (on purpose). Having arrived at this point of non-action, there is nothing which he does not do.

3 He who gets as his own all under heaven does so by giving himself no trouble (with that end). If one take trouble (with that end), he is not equal to getting as his own all under heaven.

REFLECTION

In study, you add something every day. In the Tao, you let go of something every day. Let go, and let go again, until you reach non-doing, and then nothing is left undone. This is a beautiful balance to modern self-improvement, which nearly always means adding: new habits, new tools, new goals. Here growth means subtracting effort, clutter, worry, and the urge to manage everything. The chapter adds that the world is won by those who do not meddle; whoever keeps busy interfering will never truly hold it. Less striving can mean more real effect.

PRACTICE

Remove one thing from your day: a recurring task, an app, a commitment that no longer serves. Do not replace it with anything. Notice the space it leaves.

KEY LINE

He who devotes himself to learning (seeks) from day to day to increase (his knowledge); he who devotes himself to the Tao (seeks) from day to day to diminish (his doing).

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 49

1 The sage has no invariable mind of his own; he makes the mind of the people his mind.

2 To those who are good (to me), I am good; and to those who are not good (to me), I am also good;—and thus (all) get to be good. To those who are sincere (with me), I am sincere; and to those who are not sincere (with me), I am also sincere;—and thus (all) get to be sincere.

3 The sage has in the world an appearance of indecision, and keeps his mind in a state of indifference to all. The people all keep their eyes and ears directed to him, and he deals with them all as his children.

REFLECTION

The sage has no fixed mind of his own; he takes the hearts of the people as his own. He is good to those who are good and also good to those who are not, and so goodness spreads. He trusts the trustworthy and also the untrustworthy, and so trust grows. To the world he seems undecided and open, and he treats people as his children. This is a demanding teaching. It does not mean being naive. It means that our response does not have to mirror how others treat us. Kindness that depends on being earned is just a trade; steady kindness can change the people around it.

PRACTICE

Think of one person who has been unkind or unreliable toward you. Today, offer them one small, sincere courtesy, without expecting anything in return and without telling anyone.

KEY LINE

To those who are good (to me), I am good;
and to those who are not good (to me), I am
also good;—and thus (all) get to be good.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 50

1 Men come forth and live; they enter (again) and die.

2 Of every ten three are ministers of life (to themselves); and three are ministers of death.

3 There are also three in every ten whose aim is to live, but whose movements tend to the land (or place) of death. And for what reason? Because of their excessive endeavours to perpetuate life.

4 But I have heard that he who is skilful in managing the life entrusted to him for a time travels on the land without having to shun rhinoceros or tiger, and enters a host without having to avoid buff coat or sharp weapon. The rhinoceros finds no place in him into which to thrust its horn, nor the tiger a place in which to fix its claws, nor the weapon a place to admit its point. And for what reason? Because there is in him no place of death.

REFLECTION

We come out into life and go back into death. Some people lean toward life, some toward death, and some, by trying too hard to cling to life, move toward death anyway. Then a strange picture: the person who knows how to care for life walks among rhinos and tigers, and enters battle, and finds no harm, because there is "no place of death" in him. This is an image, not a promise of protection. It suggests a person who is not ruled by fear, not stiff and grasping,

and so does not offer the world a weak point to strike. Anxious overprotection of ourselves can be its own kind of danger.

PRACTICE

Notice one thing you avoid out of fear more than real risk. Take one small, safe step toward it today and observe how your body responds.

KEY LINE

Because there is in him no place of death.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 51

1 All things are produced by the Tao, and nourished by its outflowing operation. They receive their forms according to the nature of each, and are completed according to the circumstances of their condition. Therefore all things without exception honour the Tao, and exalt its outflowing operation.

2 This honouring of the Tao and exalting of its operation is not the result of any ordination, but always a spontaneous tribute.

3 Thus it is that the Tao produces (all things), nourishes them, brings them to their full growth, nurses them, completes them, matures them, maintains them, and overspreads them.

4 It produces them and makes no claim to the possession of them; it carries them through their processes and does not vaunt its ability in doing so; it brings them to maturity and exercises no control over them; —this is called its mysterious operation.

REFLECTION

The Tao gives life, and its Te, its virtue or outflowing power, nourishes. Things take their form and are shaped by circumstance. So all things honor the Tao and value its virtue, not because anyone commands it, but naturally. The chapter lists what the Tao does: it produces, feeds, raises, nurses, completes, ripens, protects, and covers. Then the key turn: it gives life but does not possess; it acts but does not boast; it leads but does not control. This is the

"mysterious" virtue. It is a portrait of the best kind of parent, mentor, or leader: one who helps others grow fully, then lets them be their own.

PRACTICE

Think of someone you support or guide. Today, give them one decision you would normally make for them, and accept their choice without quietly correcting it later.

KEY LINE

It produces them and makes no
claim to the possession of them;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 52

1 (The Tao) which originated all under the sky is to be considered as the mother of them all.

2 When the mother is found, we know what her children should be. When one knows that he is his mother's child, and proceeds to guard (the qualities of) the mother that belong to him, to the end of his life he will be free from all peril.

3 Let him keep his mouth closed, and shut up the portals (of his nostrils), and all his life he will be exempt from laborious exertion. Let him keep his mouth open, and (spend his breath) in the promotion of his affairs, and all his life there will be no safety for him.

4 The perception of what is small is (the secret of) clear-sightedness; the guarding of what is soft and tender is (the secret of) strength.

5 *Who uses well his light,*
Reverting to its (source so) bright,
Will from his body ward all blight,
And hides the unchanging from men's sight.

REFLECTION

The world has a beginning, which the chapter calls its mother. Know the mother and you understand the children; know the children and hold to the mother, and life is free from danger. Then practical advice: close your mouth,

shut the doors of the senses, and life will not wear you out; keep them always open, busy with affairs, and there will be no rest. Seeing what is small is clarity; keeping to softness is strength. The lines about warding blight from the body are best kept as image: a life guarded by attention. Today this reads as a call to limit inputs, guard your attention, and return often to your source.

PRACTICE

For one hour today, close the doors: phone away, notifications off, no talking unless needed. Spend that hour on one quiet task, then notice how your mind feels afterward.

KEY LINE

The perception of what is small is (the secret of) clear-sightedness; the guarding of what is soft and tender is (the secret of) strength.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 53

1 If I were suddenly to become known, and (put into a position to) conduct (a government) according to the Great Tao, what I should be most afraid of would be a boastful display.

2 The great Tao (or way) is very level and easy; but people love the by-ways.

3 Their court(-yards and buildings) shall be well kept, but their fields shall be ill-cultivated, and their granaries very empty. They shall wear elegant and ornamented robes, carry a sharp sword at their girdle, pamper themselves in eating and drinking, and have a superabundance of property and wealth;—such (princes) may be called robbers and boasters. This is contrary to the Tao surely!

REFLECTION

The great Way is level and easy, yet people love side paths. Then comes a sharp political picture: palaces spotless while fields lie neglected and granaries stand empty; rulers in fine robes with swords at their sides, overfed, sitting on heaps of wealth. The chapter calls them robbers and boasters. Written about the courts of ancient China, it still speaks plainly about any leadership that polishes its image while ordinary needs go unmet. On a personal level, it asks whether our own lives look good outside while something essential goes hungry inside. The plain road is usually the right one, and we often choose detours because they flatter us.

PRACTICE

Look at where your time and money went this week. Name one place where appearance won over substance. Move one hour or one purchase back to what truly matters.

KEY LINE

The great Tao (or way) is very level
and easy; but people love the by-ways.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 54

1 *What (Tao's) skilful planter plants*
Can never be uptorn;
What his skilful arms enfold,
From him can ne'er be borne.
Sons shall bring in lengthening line,
Sacrifices to his shrine.

2 *Tao when nursed within one's self,*
His vigour will make true;
And where the family it rules
What riches will accrue!
The neighbourhood where it prevails
In thriving will abound;
And when 'tis seen throughout the state,
Good fortune will be found.
Employ it the kingdom o'er,
And men thrive all around.

3 In this way the effect will be seen in the person, by the observation of different cases; in the family; in the neighbourhood; in the state; and in the kingdom.

4 How do I know that this effect is sure to hold thus all under the sky? By this (method of observation).

REFLECTION

What is well planted cannot be uprooted; what is well held cannot slip away. Cultivate the Tao in yourself and your virtue becomes real. Cultivate it in the family and it overflows. In the village it lasts; in the state it flourishes; across the world it spreads everywhere. The chapter then gives its method: look at a person to understand persons, at a family to understand families, and so on outward. Change begins small and close. In a time when we often feel helpless before vast problems, this is steadying advice. Start with your own habits, then your home, then your street. Real influence grows outward from roots.

PRACTICE

Choose one value you want more of in the world, such as patience or honesty. Practice it deliberately once today with yourself, once with your family, and once with a neighbor or coworker.

KEY LINE

What (Tao's) skilful planter plants Can never be uptorn;

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 55

1 He who has in himself abundantly the attributes (of the Tao) is like an infant. Poisonous insects will not sting him; fierce beasts will not seize him; birds of prey will not strike him.

2 (The infant's) bones are weak and its sinews soft, but yet its grasp is firm. It knows not yet the union of male and female, and yet its virile member may be excited;—showing the perfection of its physical essence. All day long it will cry without its throat becoming hoarse;—showing the harmony (in its constitution).

3 *To him by whom this harmony is known,*
(The secret of) the unchanging (Tao) is shown,
And in the knowledge wisdom finds its throne.
All life-increasing arts to evil turn;
Where the mind makes the vital breath to burn,
(False) is the strength, (and o'er it we should mourn.)

4 When things have become strong, they (then) become old, which may be said to be contrary to the Tao. Whatever is contrary to the Tao soon ends.

REFLECTION

The person who lives close to the Tao is compared to a newborn. A baby has soft bones and loose muscles, yet its little fist holds on tight. It can cry all day

without going hoarse, because nothing in it is strained. The chapter treats this as a picture of inner harmony, not as a promise of protection from harm. The warning comes at the end: when we push our strength and force our energy, we grow stiff and wear out early. Today this might mean noticing how much effort we spend bracing, gripping and pushing. Real strength often looks relaxed. It holds firmly where it needs to and stays soft everywhere else.

PRACTICE

Hold a cup, a pen or your phone and notice how hard you are gripping. Let go of half that effort while still holding it securely. Then check your jaw, shoulders and hands, and soften each one the same way.

KEY LINE

When things have become strong, they (then) become old, which may be said to be contrary to the Tao.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 56

1 He who knows (the Tao) does not (care to) speak (about it); he who is (ever ready to) speak about it does not know it.

2 He (who knows it) will keep his mouth shut and close the portals (of his nostrils). He will blunt his sharp points and unravel the complications of things; he will attemper his brightness, and bring himself into agreement with the obscurity (of others). This is called 'the Mysterious Agreement.'

3 (Such an one) cannot be treated familiarly or distantly; he is beyond all consideration of profit or injury; of nobility or meanness:—he is the noblest man under heaven.

REFLECTION

Those who truly understand the Tao are not eager to talk about it, and those who talk about it constantly have usually missed it. The chapter describes a person who closes the mouth, files down sharp edges, untangles knots, dims their own shine and blends in with ordinary people. Legge calls this "the Mysterious Agreement." Such a person cannot be bought with gain or frightened by loss, flattered by status or shamed by low rank. For a modern reader this is a quiet challenge to the habit of explaining, posting and proving. Some understanding grows best when it is lived rather than announced, and a calm person is often the one with the least to prove.

PRACTICE

For one conversation today, do not share your opinion unless someone asks for it. Listen, ask one honest question, and let the other person have the last word. Afterward, notice whether anything was actually lost.

KEY LINE

He will blunt his sharp points and
unravel the complications of things

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 57

1 A state may be ruled by (measures of) correction; weapons of war may be used with crafty dexterity; (but) the kingdom is made one's own (only) by freedom from action and purpose.

2 How do I know that it is so? By these facts:—In the kingdom the multiplication of prohibitive enactments increases the poverty of the people; the more implements to add to their profit that the people have, the greater disorder is there in the state and clan; the more acts of crafty dexterity that men possess, the more do strange contrivances appear; the more display there is of legislation, the more thieves and robbers there are.

3 Therefore a sage has said, 'I will do nothing (of purpose), and the people will be transformed of themselves; I will be fond of keeping still, and the people will of themselves become correct. I will take no trouble about it, and the people will of themselves become rich; I will manifest no ambition, and the people will of themselves attain to the primitive simplicity.'

REFLECTION

This chapter is about how heavy-handed control backfires. You can run a state by rules and fight wars by cunning, but you win people's trust only by not forcing them. The more prohibitions, the poorer the people; the more laws on display, the more thieves. Written for rulers of warring states in ancient China, it

reads today like advice for managers, parents and anyone tempted to fix problems with one more rule. The sage's promise is simple: if I stay still and stop meddling, people will settle and find their own way. This is not neglect. It is trust that a well-made situation can largely take care of itself.

PRACTICE

Pick one rule, reminder or check-in you impose on someone, at work or at home. Drop it for a week, or loosen it, and watch what happens. Note honestly whether things fall apart or quietly sort themselves out.

KEY LINE

I will be fond of keeping still, and the people will of themselves become correct.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 58

1 *The government that seems the most unwise,*
Oft goodness to the people best supplies;
That which is meddling, touching everything,
Will work but ill, and disappointment bring.

MISERY!—HAPPINESS is to be found by its side! Happiness!—misery lurks beneath it! Who knows what either will come to in the end?

2 Shall we then dispense with correction? The (method of) correction shall by a turn become distortion, and the good in it shall by a turn become evil. The delusion of the people (on this point) has indeed subsisted for a long time.

3 Therefore the sage is (like) a square which cuts no one (with its angles); (like) a corner which injures no one (with its sharpness). He is straightforward, but allows himself no license; he is bright, but does not dazzle.

REFLECTION

A government that looks sleepy and unimpressive may serve people best, while one that pokes into everything breeds disappointment. Then the chapter widens into one of its most famous thoughts: good and bad fortune lie side by side. Happiness can hide the seed of trouble, and trouble can carry the seed of something good. Who knows how either will turn out? Even correction can

twist into harm if it is pushed too far. The sage is pictured as a square with corners that do not cut: firm and honest, but not sharp, bright but not blinding. In daily life this invites patience with events. We rarely know yet what today's luck or loss will mean.

PRACTICE

Think of one past event you once called a disaster. Write down one good thing that came from it, however small. Then think of one recent "win" and ask, without worry, what it might cost you later.

KEY LINE

Misery!—happiness is to be found by its
side! Happiness!—misery lurks beneath it!

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 59

1 For regulating the human (in our constitution) and rendering the (proper) service to the heavenly, there is nothing like moderation.

2 It is only by this moderation that there is effected an early return (to man's normal state). That early return is what I call the repeated accumulation of the attributes (of the Tao). With that repeated accumulation of those attributes, there comes the subjugation (of every obstacle to such return). Of this subjugation we know not what shall be the limit; and when one knows not what the limit shall be, he may be the ruler of a state.

3 He who possesses the mother of the state may continue long. His case is like that (of the plant) of which we say that its roots are deep and its flower stalks firm:—this is the way to secure that its enduring life shall long be seen.

REFLECTION

The single word at the center of this chapter is moderation, which can also be read as thrift or careful restraint. Whether caring for yourself or governing a country, nothing works better than not using up your resources. Restraint lets you return early to a natural state, and over time it builds up a quiet store of inner strength, so that obstacles give way and your capacity seems to have no clear limit. The closing image is a plant with deep roots and a firm stem. This is a picture of steadiness, not a health promise. Today it might mean keeping

something in reserve: time, money, energy, attention, so that you are not always running on empty.

PRACTICE

Choose one resource you tend to spend to the last drop, such as evenings, money or patience. Today, deliberately leave a little of it unspent. Notice how it feels to have something in reserve.

KEY LINE

there is nothing like moderation.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 60

1 Governing a great state is like cooking small fish.

2 Let the kingdom be governed according to the Tao, and the manes of the departed will not manifest their spiritual energy. It is not that those manes have not that spiritual energy, but it will not be employed to hurt men. It is not that it could not hurt men, but neither does the ruling sage hurt them.

3 When these two do not injuriously affect each other, their good influences converge in the virtue (of the Tao).

REFLECTION

"Governing a great state is like cooking small fish." If you keep flipping and stirring a small fish in the pan, it falls apart. The lesson is light handling: do not over-manage what is delicate. The chapter then says that when a land is run in harmony with the Tao, even the spirits of the dead do no harm. Ancient readers took this literally; today we might read it as a picture of a society where fear and grievance lose their power because no one is being harmed from above. The idea applies to teams, families and projects. Many good things are spoiled not by neglect but by constant poking.

PRACTICE

Name one thing you keep checking or adjusting: a plan, a document, a plant, a child's homework. Set it up well once, then leave it alone for a full day before

touching it again.

KEY LINE

Governing a great state is like cooking small fish.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 61

1 What makes a great state is its being (like) a low-lying, down-flowing (stream);—it becomes the centre to which tend (all the small states) under heaven.

2 (To illustrate from) the case of all females:—the female always overcomes the male by her stillness. Stillness may be considered (a sort of) abasement.

3 Thus it is that a great state, by condescending to small states, gains them for itself; and that small states, by abasing themselves to a great state, win it over to them. In the one case the abasement leads to gaining adherents, in the other case to procuring favour.

4 The great state only wishes to unite men together and nourish them; a small state only wishes to be received by, and to serve, the other. Each gets what it desires, but the great state must learn to abase itself.

REFLECTION

A great state, the chapter says, should be like the low ground where rivers flow together. Because it lies low, everything comes to it. The text uses the image of the female, who wins by stillness rather than force, a figure of receptivity that Legge renders in the language of his time. Large states gain small ones by bowing to them, and small states win the protection of large ones by bowing in return. Each gets what it needs, but the bigger party must learn to be humble first. Today this fits any relationship with a power gap: boss and staff, parent

and child, big company and small partner. The stronger side makes peace easier by going low.

PRACTICE

In a relationship where you hold more power, take the humble step first today. Ask for the other person's view before giving yours, admit a mistake, or thank them for something specific.

KEY LINE

the great state must learn to abase itself.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 62

1 *Tao has of all things the most honoured place.*
No treasures give good men so rich a grace;
Bad men it guards, and doth their ill efface.

2 (Its) admirable words can purchase honour; (its) admirable deeds can raise their performer above others. Even men who are not good are not abandoned by it.

3 Therefore when the sovereign occupies his place as the Son of Heaven, and he has appointed his three ducal ministers, though (a prince) were to send in a round symbol-of-rank large enough to fill both the hands, and that as the precursor of the team of horses (in the courtyard), such an offering would not be equal to (a lesson of) this Tao, which one might present on his knees.

4 Why was it that the ancients prized this Tao so much? Was it not because it could be got by seeking for it, and the guilty could escape (from the stain of their guilt) by it? This is the reason why all under heaven consider it the most valuable thing.

REFLECTION

The Tao is described as the most honored thing of all, a treasure to good people and a shelter even for those who are not good. It does not throw anyone away. The chapter pictures a grand court ceremony with jade tokens and teams of horses, and says that all of it is worth less than quietly offering the Tao itself.

Why did the ancients prize it? Because it can be found by anyone who looks, and because through it even people who have done wrong can make a fresh start. For modern readers this is a hopeful chapter. The Way is not a prize for the already perfect; it is open to everyone, including the person who has failed.

PRACTICE

Think of someone you have quietly written off, maybe even yourself. Write one sentence that leaves the door open to them, such as "They are still learning." Read it once in the morning and once at night.

KEY LINE

Even men who are not good are not abandoned by it.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 63

1 (It is the way of the Tao) to act without (thinking of) acting; to conduct affairs without (feeling the) trouble of them; to taste without discerning any flavour; to consider what is small as great, and a few as many; and to recompense injury with kindness.

2 (The master of it) anticipates things that are difficult while they are easy, and does things that would become great while they are small. All difficult things in the world are sure to arise from a previous state in which they were easy, and all great things from one in which they were small. Therefore the sage, while he never does what is great, is able on that account to accomplish the greatest things.

3 He who lightly promises is sure to keep but little faith; he who is continually thinking things easy is sure to find them difficult. Therefore the sage sees difficulty even in what seems easy, and so never has any difficulties.

REFLECTION

This chapter is full of practical wisdom. Act without making a fuss about acting. Treat small things as important. Repay injury with kindness. Above all, handle hard things while they are still easy and big things while they are still small, because every great difficulty starts as a small one. The sage never takes on something "huge," and that is exactly how huge things get done. There is also a warning: people who promise lightly rarely keep their word, and people who

think everything is easy run into the most trouble. For daily life, this is a guide to work, health habits and relationships alike. Respect the small step and the early sign.

PRACTICE

Find one task you have been putting off because it feels big. Do only its smallest first piece today, something that takes under ten minutes, and stop there.

KEY LINE

All difficult things in the world are sure to arise
from a previous state in which they were easy

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 64

1 That which is at rest is easily kept hold of; before a thing has given indications of its presence, it is easy to take measures against it; that which is brittle is easily broken; that which is very small is easily dispersed. Action should be taken before a thing has made its appearance; order should be secured before disorder has begun.

2 The tree which fills the arms grew from the tiniest sprout; the tower of nine storeys rose from a (small) heap of earth; the journey of a thousand li commenced with a single step.

3 He who acts (with an ulterior purpose) does harm; he who takes hold of a thing (in the same way) loses his hold. The sage does not act (so), and therefore does no harm; he does not lay hold (so), and therefore does not lose his hold. (But) people in their conduct of affairs are constantly ruining them when they are on the eve of success. If they were careful at the end, as (they should be) at the beginning, they would not so ruin them.

4 Therefore the sage desires what (other men) do not desire, and does not prize things difficult to get; he learns what (other men) do not learn, and turns back to what the multitude of men have passed by. Thus he helps the natural development of all things, and does not dare to act (with an ulterior purpose of his own).

REFLECTION

Things are easiest to manage before they start. A problem not yet visible is easy to head off; something fragile is easy to break apart before it hardens. The chapter gives three famous images: a huge tree grew from a tiny sprout, a tall tower from a heap of earth, and a journey of a thousand li began with one step (a li is a traditional Chinese unit of distance). It also notes that people often ruin their work right at the edge of success. If we stayed as careful at the end as at the beginning, we would fail far less. Today this speaks to beginnings and endings alike: start small, and finish with care.

PRACTICE

Think of a project you are close to finishing. Before you call it done, slow down and give the last step the same attention you gave the first. Check one detail you would normally skip.

KEY LINE

the journey of a thousand li commenced with a single step.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 65

1 The ancients who showed their skill in practising the Tao did so, not to enlighten the people, but rather to make them simple and ignorant.

2 The difficulty in governing the people arises from their having much knowledge. He who (tries to) govern a state by his wisdom is a scourge to it; while he who does not (try to) do so is a blessing.

3 He who knows these two things finds in them also his model and rule. Ability to know this model and rule constitutes what we call the mysterious excellence (of a governor). Deep and far-reaching is such mysterious excellence, showing indeed its possessor as opposite to others, but leading them to a great conformity to him.

REFLECTION

This is one of the hardest chapters for a modern reader. It says the wise rulers of old did not try to "enlighten" the people but to keep them simple, and that a ruler who governs by cleverness is a curse to the land. Read in its time, it is an attack on rulers who used schemes, propaganda and manipulation, and on the crafty know-how that set people against each other. Today we rightly value education and an informed public, so we should not read it as praise of keeping people ignorant. What still speaks to us is the warning against cunning: leadership by tricks breeds tricks in return. Plainness and honesty build deeper trust.

PRACTICE

Notice one place where you are using cleverness to manage people: spin, a strategic omission, a persuasive trick. Replace it today with a plain, honest sentence, and see how it lands.

KEY LINE

He who (tries to) govern a state
by his wisdom is a scourge to it

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 66

1 That whereby the rivers and seas are able to receive the homage and tribute of all the valley streams, is their skill in being lower than they;—it is thus that they are the kings of them all. So it is that the sage (ruler), wishing to be above men, puts himself by his words below them, and, wishing to be before them, places his person behind them.

2 In this way though he has his place above them, men do not feel his weight, nor though he has his place before them, do they feel it an injury to them.

3 Therefore all in the world delight to exalt him and do not weary of him. Because he does not strive, no one finds it possible to strive with him.

REFLECTION

Rivers and seas become the kings of all valley streams simply because they lie lower. Every stream runs to them without being forced. The sage leader works the same way: to be above people, they speak humbly; to lead, they put themselves behind. As a result, people do not feel the leader as a weight or a threat, and are glad to support them. Because the leader does not compete, no one can compete with them. This is an early, clear statement of what we might now call servant leadership. It also applies far beyond leadership. People tend to gather around those who make room for them rather than those who tower over them.

PRACTICE

In your next meeting or group conversation, speak last instead of first. Let others share their ideas fully, build on one of them, and notice how the room responds to you.

KEY LINE

Because he does not strive, no one
finds it possible to strive with him.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 67

1 All the world says that, while my Tao is great, it yet appears to be inferior (to other systems of teaching). Now it is just its greatness that makes it seem to be inferior. If it were like any other (system), for long would its smallness have been known!

2 But I have three precious things which I prize and hold fast. The first is gentleness; the second is economy; and the third is shrinking from taking precedence of others.

3 With that gentleness I can be bold; with that economy I can be liberal; shrinking from taking precedence of others, I can become a vessel of the highest honour. Now-a-days they give up gentleness and are all for being bold; economy, and are all for being liberal; the hindmost place, and seek only to be foremost;—(of all which the end is) death.

4 Gentleness is sure to be victorious even in battle, and firmly to maintain its ground. Heaven will save its possessor, by his (very) gentleness protecting him.

REFLECTION

People say this teaching seems great but also small and odd, and the chapter answers that its greatness is exactly why it looks unimpressive. Then comes a personal treasure list: three precious things. The first is gentleness, or compassion; the second is economy, a careful simplicity; the third is not rushing to be first. From gentleness comes courage, from thrift comes generosity, and

from staying back comes real standing. The chapter warns that people who drop these and chase boldness, lavishness and first place are heading for ruin. It is one of the most useful summaries in the whole book, a short list you could keep on a card in your pocket.

PRACTICE

Write the three treasures on a small card: gentleness, economy, not rushing to be first. Carry it today. At the end of the day, mark which one you practiced and which one you forgot.

KEY LINE

The first is gentleness; the second is economy; and the third is shrinking from taking precedence of others.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 68

He who in (Tao's) wars has skill
Assumes no martial port;
He who fights with most good will
To rage makes no resort.
He who vanquishes yet still
Keeps from his foes apart;
He whose hests men most fulfil
Yet humbly plies his art.

Thus we say, 'He ne'er contends,
And therein is his might.'
Thus we say, 'Men's wills he bends,
That they with him unite.'
Thus we say, 'Like Heaven's his ends,
No sage of old more bright.'

REFLECTION

Legge turns this short chapter into a rhymed poem. Its point is that the best warrior does not look warlike, the best fighter does not lose their temper, and the best winner does not chase after the enemy. The best leader of people stays humble. This is called the strength of not contending, and it brings people into harmony. The language is military because the text came from an age of constant war, but the lesson is about anger and ego. In an argument, a

negotiation or a tense family moment, the person who stays calm and does not need to dominate is often the one who quietly shapes the outcome.

PRACTICE

The next time you feel a flash of anger, pause for three slow breaths before you speak. Then say only what is needed, in a lower voice than you planned.

KEY LINE

He who fights with most good will To rage makes no resort.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 69

1 A master of the art of war has said, 'I do not dare to be the host (to commence the war); I prefer to be the guest (to act on the defensive). I do not dare to advance an inch; I prefer to retire a foot.' This is called marshalling the ranks where there are no ranks; baring the arms (to fight) where there are no arms to bare; grasping the weapon where there is no weapon to grasp; advancing against the enemy where there is no enemy.

2 There is no calamity greater than lightly engaging in war. To do that is near losing (the gentleness) which is so precious. Thus it is that when opposing weapons are (actually) crossed, he who deplores (the situation) conquers.

REFLECTION

The chapter quotes a master strategist who prefers to be the "guest," defending rather than attacking, and who would rather step back a foot than push forward an inch. It then gives a string of paradoxes: marching where there are no ranks, holding a weapon where there is none. The point is that one can be ready without being aggressive. No disaster is worse than starting a fight lightly, because it costs the gentleness the previous chapter called precious. When conflict cannot be avoided, the side that grieves over it tends to prevail. Written for war, this applies to every quarrel. Do not be the one who starts it, and never enjoy it.

PRACTICE

Think of an ongoing disagreement. Instead of planning your next point, plan one step back: a concession, a pause, or a question. Use it the next time the topic comes up.

KEY LINE

There is no calamity greater than lightly engaging in war.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 70

1 My words are very easy to know, and very easy to practise; but there is no one in the world who is able to know and able to practise them.

2 There is an originating and all-comprehending (principle) in my words, and an authoritative law for the things (which I enforce). It is because they do not know these, that men do not know me.

3 They who know me are few, and I am on that account (the more) to be prized. It is thus that the sage wears (a poor garb of) hair cloth, while he carries his (signet of) jade in his bosom.

REFLECTION

Here the speaker almost sighs. These words are very easy to understand and very easy to practice, yet hardly anyone understands or practices them. There is a root and an order behind them, but people miss it, and so they miss the speaker too. The closing image is lovely: the sage wears rough cloth on the outside while carrying jade close to the heart. Real value often hides under a plain surface. For us, this is a reminder that the hard part of a simple teaching is not learning it but living it. It is also an invitation to look twice at plain people and plain things, where treasures are often kept.

PRACTICE

Choose one simple teaching from this book that you already understand, such as “do the small thing first.” Practice it three times today on purpose, and note

each time in a few words.

KEY LINE

My words are very easy to know, and very easy to practise

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 71

1 To know and yet (think) we do not know is the highest (attainment); not to know (and yet think) we do know is a disease.

2 It is simply by being pained at (the thought of) having this disease that we are preserved from it. The sage has not the disease. He knows the pain that would be inseparable from it, and therefore he does not have it.

REFLECTION

This short chapter is about honest knowing. To know and still hold that knowledge lightly, as if you do not fully know, is the highest state. To not know but think you do is a sickness. The way to avoid this sickness is to be aware of it and dislike it; the sage is free of it precisely because he sees it clearly. In a world full of quick opinions and confident experts, this is a refreshing standard. Saying "I'm not sure" is not weakness. It is a kind of health. The person who can see the edges of their own knowledge keeps learning, while the one who cannot stays stuck.

PRACTICE

Today, say "I don't know" or "I'm not sure" at least once when it is true, instead of guessing. Then, if it matters, go and find out.

KEY LINE

not to know (and yet think) we do know is a disease.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 72

1 When the people do not fear what they ought to fear, that which is their great dread will come on them.

2 Let them not thoughtlessly indulge themselves in their ordinary life; let them not act as if weary of what that life depends on.

3 It is by avoiding such indulgence that such weariness does not arise.

4 Therefore the sage knows (these things) of himself, but does not parade (his knowledge); loves, but does not (appear to set a) value on, himself. And thus he puts the latter alternative away and makes choice of the former.

REFLECTION

When people lose a healthy sense of caution, what they most fear will eventually come upon them. The chapter warns against living carelessly and against becoming weary of, or disregarding, the very things life rests on. Legge's wording is dense, but the sense is that a ruler should not crowd people's homes or crush their livelihood, and that individuals should not treat their own lives with neglect. The sage knows himself but does not show off, and cares for himself without self-importance. Today this might suggest a balanced self-respect: look after the basics of your life quietly, without making yourself the center of attention.

PRACTICE

List three basic things your daily life depends on, such as sleep, a friendship, or the place you live. Do one quiet act of care for one of them today, without mentioning it to anyone.

KEY LINE

the sage knows (these things) of himself,
but does not parade (his knowledge)

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 73

1 He whose boldness appears in his daring (to do wrong, in defiance of the laws) is put to death; he whose boldness appears in his not daring (to do so) lives on. Of these two cases the one appears to be advantageous, and the other to be injurious. But

> *When Heaven's anger smites a man,*
> *Who the cause shall truly scan?*

ON THIS account the sage feels a difficulty (as to what to do in the former case).

2 It is the way of Heaven not to strive, and yet it skilfully overcomes; not to speak, and yet it is skilful in obtaining a reply; does not call, and yet men come to it of themselves. Its demonstrations are quiet, and yet its plans are skilful and effective. The meshes of the net of Heaven are large; far apart, but letting nothing escape.

REFLECTION

The chapter contrasts two kinds of courage: the daring that rushes into wrongdoing and dies, and the daring of restraint that lives. It admits that even the sage finds it hard to know why fate strikes as it does. Then it describes the way of heaven: it does not fight, yet wins; does not speak, yet gets its answer; does not call, yet things come. Its last image is famous: heaven's net is wide and its mesh is loose, yet nothing slips through. Today we might read this as a calm

trust that actions have consequences, even when we cannot see how. We do not have to force every outcome ourselves.

PRACTICE

Name one situation where you feel you must personally make sure justice is done. For today, set it down. Write it on paper, fold the paper, and let the matter rest without action.

KEY LINE

The meshes of the net of Heaven are large;
far apart, but letting nothing escape.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 74

1 The people do not fear death; to what purpose is it to (try to) frighten them with death? If the people were always in awe of death, and I could always seize those who do wrong, and put them to death, who would dare to do wrong?

2 There is always One who presides over the infliction of death. He who would inflict death in the room of him who so presides over it may be described as hewing wood instead of a great carpenter. Seldom is it that he who undertakes the hewing, instead of the great carpenter, does not cut his own hands!

REFLECTION

If people no longer fear death, threatening them with death is useless. This chapter speaks directly to rulers who governed by executions. It argues that the power over life and death belongs to a greater order, which Legge calls "One who presides," and that a ruler who takes that role on himself is like an amateur trying to do a master carpenter's work: he will almost surely cut his own hands. Historically it is a protest against harsh punishment. For modern readers, it raises lasting questions about cruelty, fear as a tool of control, and the danger of taking on powers that are not ours to use.

PRACTICE

Notice one place where you try to get results through fear: a threat, a warning, a cold silence. Today, try asking for the same result plainly and kindly instead.

KEY LINE

Seldom is it that he who undertakes the hewing, instead of the great carpenter, does not cut his own hands!

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 75

1 The people suffer from famine because of the multitude of taxes consumed by their superiors. It is through this that they suffer famine.

2 The people are difficult to govern because of the (excessive) agency of their superiors (in governing them). It is through this that they are difficult to govern.

3 The people make light of dying because of the greatness of their labours in seeking for the means of living. It is this which makes them think light of dying. Thus it is that to leave the subject of living altogether out of view is better than to set a high value on it.

REFLECTION

This is one of the most direct political chapters. The people go hungry because those above them tax too much. They are hard to govern because those above them interfere too much. They take death lightly because they must struggle so hard just to stay alive. In each case the problem starts at the top, not with the people. The chapter ends by saying that those who do not cling too tightly to life do better than those who prize it too highly. Today it reads as a sharp critique of leaders who blame the public for problems they caused themselves. Before judging how people behave, look at what weighs on them.

PRACTICE

Think of someone whose behavior frustrates you. Before judging, list two pressures they may be under that you might not see. Let that change one thing about how you speak to them today.

KEY LINE

The people suffer from famine because of the multitude of taxes consumed by their superiors.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 76

1 Man at his birth is supple and weak; at his death, firm and strong. (So it is with) all things. Trees and plants, in their early growth, are soft and brittle; at their death, dry and withered.

2 Thus it is that firmness and strength are the concomitants of death; softness and weakness, the concomitants of life.

3 Hence he who (relies on) the strength of his forces does not conquer; and a tree which is strong will fill the out-stretched arms, (and thereby invites the feller.)

4 Therefore the place of what is firm and strong is below, and that of what is soft and weak is above.

REFLECTION

At birth we are soft and supple; at death we are stiff and hard. Young plants are tender; dead ones are dry and brittle. So the chapter concludes that hardness belongs with death and softness with life. An army that relies only on force does not win, and a tree that grows too strong and thick invites the axe. In the end, the hard and strong sit below, and the soft and gentle rise above. This is a picture, not a medical claim, but it speaks clearly to daily life: rigid opinions, tight muscles and fixed habits all tend to break. Flexibility of body and mind is a sign of being alive.

PRACTICE

Stand up and stretch slowly for two minutes, moving only as far as feels easy. Then think of one opinion you hold rigidly and ask, gently, what it would cost you to loosen it a little.

KEY LINE

softness and weakness, the concomitants of life.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 77

1 May not the Way (or Tao) of Heaven be compared to the (method of) bending a bow? The (part of the bow) which was high is brought low, and what was low is raised up. (So Heaven) diminishes where there is superabundance, and supplements where there is deficiency.

2 It is the Way of Heaven to diminish superabundance, and to supplement deficiency. It is not so with the way of man. He takes away from those who have not enough to add to his own superabundance.

3 Who can take his own superabundance and therewith serve all under heaven? Only he who is in possession of the Tao!

4 Therefore the (ruling) sage acts without claiming the results as his; he achieves his merit and does not rest (arrogantly) in it:—he does not wish to display his superiority.

REFLECTION

The way of heaven is compared to drawing a bow: the high end comes down and the low end comes up. Nature tends to balance things, taking from excess and adding where there is lack. People, the chapter says, often do the opposite and take from those who have little to add to what they already have. Only someone in tune with the Tao gives away their surplus to serve others. The sage does good without claiming credit and does not linger over achievements. Today this is a clear call to fairness and generosity, and a quiet question for each of us: where do I have more than enough, and who could use it?

PRACTICE

Look around for one thing you have more of than you need: time, clothes, skills, money, attention. Give a small part of it away today to someone who has less, without announcing it.

KEY LINE

It is the Way of Heaven to diminish superabundance, and to supplement deficiency.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 78

1 There is nothing in the world more soft and weak than water, and yet for attacking things that are firm and strong there is nothing that can take precedence of it;—for there is nothing (so effectual) for which it can be changed.

2 Every one in the world knows that the soft overcomes the hard, and the weak the strong, but no one is able to carry it out in practice.

3 *Therefore a sage has said,*
'He who accepts his state's reproach,
Is hailed therefore its altars' lord;
To him who bears men's direful woes
They all the name of King accord.'

4 Words that are strictly true seem to be paradoxical.

REFLECTION

Nothing in the world is softer or weaker than water, yet nothing beats it at wearing down what is hard and strong. Everyone knows that the soft overcomes the hard and the gentle overcomes the tough, yet hardly anyone lives this way. The chapter quotes an old saying: the one who takes on the shame and the troubles of the country is the one fit to lead it. It ends with a line worth remembering: true words often sound like contradictions. This is a central image of the whole book. Water does not fight. It keeps going, finds the low places and gets around obstacles, and over time it shapes stone.

PRACTICE

Find a problem you have been pushing against hard. Instead of pressing harder today, try going around it: ask for help, change the timing, or approach it from a different side, the way water would.

KEY LINE

Every one in the world knows that the soft overcomes the hard, and the weak the strong, but no one is able to carry it out in practice.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 79

1 When a reconciliation is effected (between two parties) after a great animosity, there is sure to be a grudge remaining (in the mind of the one who was wrong). And how can this be beneficial (to the other)?

2 Therefore (to guard against this), the sage keeps the left-hand portion of the record of the engagement, and does not insist on the (speedy) fulfilment of it by the other party. (So), he who has the attributes (of the Tao) regards (only) the conditions of the engagement, while he who has not those attributes regards only the conditions favourable to himself.

3 In the Way of Heaven, there is no partiality of love; it is always on the side of the good man.

REFLECTION

Even after a big quarrel is settled, some resentment usually lingers. How can that be called a good outcome? The sage handles this by holding the creditor's half of a contract, Legge's "left-hand portion" of an old split tally, but never pressing the other party to pay. People in tune with the Tao look to the agreement itself; people who are not look only for their own advantage. The way of heaven has no favorites, yet it tends to stand with those who are good. Today this speaks to forgiveness, debts and grudges. Sometimes the wisest move is to hold the receipt and simply not demand it.

PRACTICE

Think of a small debt someone owes you: a favor, an apology, money. Decide today to stop waiting for it. If it helps, write "settled" next to their name in a notebook.

KEY LINE

In the Way of Heaven, there is no partiality of love; it is always on the side of the good man.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 80

1 In a little state with a small population, I would so order it, that, though there were individuals with the abilities of ten or a hundred men, there should be no employment of them; I would make the people, while looking on death as a grievous thing, yet not remove elsewhere (to avoid it).

2 Though they had boats and carriages, they should have no occasion to ride in them; though they had buff coats and sharp weapons, they should have no occasion to don or use them.

3 I would make the people return to the use of knotted cords (instead of the written characters).

4 They should think their (coarse) food sweet; their (plain) clothes beautiful; their (poor) dwellings places of rest; and their common (simple) ways sources of enjoyment.

5 There should be a neighbouring state within sight, and the voices of the fowls and dogs should be heard all the way from it to us, but I would make the people to old age, even to death, not have any intercourse with it.

REFLECTION

Here is a picture of a small, quiet country with few people. They have tools and boats and weapons but no need to use them, and they enjoy their plain food,

simple clothes, modest homes and local customs. They can hear the dogs and roosters of the next village, yet they grow old without needing to visit it. Taken literally as a political program, with knotted cords instead of writing and no travel, it would trouble most modern readers. Read as an image, it is a gentle portrait of contentment: a life that does not need to go anywhere else, buy anything more or prove anything, in order to be enough.

PRACTICE

Tonight, eat a simple meal slowly and treat it as a pleasure, not a refueling stop. Name one thing about your home or routine that is already good enough, and say thank you for it.

KEY LINE

They should think their (coarse) food sweet; their (plain) clothes beautiful; their (poor) dwellings places of rest; and their common (simple) ways sources of enjoyment.

MY OWN NOTES

Chapter 81

1 Sincere words are not fine; fine words are not sincere. Those who are skilled (in the Tao) do not dispute (about it); the disputatious are not skilled in it. Those who know (the Tao) are not extensively learned; the extensively learned do not know it.

2 The sage does not accumulate (for himself). The more that he expends for others, the more does he possess of his own; the more that he gives to others, the more does he have himself.

3 With all the sharpness of the Way of Heaven, it injures not; with all the doing in the way of the sage he does not strive.

REFLECTION

The book ends with a short, balanced chapter. Sincere words are not fancy, and fancy words are not sincere. Those who truly understand do not argue about it, and those who argue do not understand. Wise people are not necessarily well read, and well-read people are not necessarily wise. The sage does not hoard. The more he gives to others, the more he has; the more he spends for others, the richer he becomes. Heaven's way helps without harming, and the sage's way acts without fighting. It is a fitting close: speak plainly, argue less, give more. After eighty chapters of images, the final lesson is simple enough to live tomorrow.

PRACTICE

Today, give one thing away freely and say one plain, honest sentence where you might normally dress your words up. In the evening, notice whether you feel poorer or richer.

KEY LINE

The more that he expends for others,
the more does he possess of his own

MY OWN NOTES

The 30-Day Practice

Reading the *Tao Te Ching* is one thing. Living a little of it is another. This practice is a bridge between the two.

For thirty days, you will take one line from the text and one small task into your ordinary life. The tasks are modest on purpose. None of them asks you to change everything. Most take a few minutes, and some take no extra time at all, only a different kind of attention to what you are already doing.

The month has four movements. **Week one** is about stillness and emptiness: making a little room inside. **Week two** turns to softness, water, and yielding. **Week three** looks at simplicity, desire, and the quiet wealth of having enough. **Week four** brings the teaching into work and relationships: leading, serving, and acting without forcing. The last two days are for looking back and choosing what you want to keep.

Each morning, read the day's line slowly, twice, once aloud if you can. If you like, read the whole chapter it comes from. Then carry the task with you. In the evening, take a moment to write a few words on the page: what you noticed, what was hard, what surprised you.

If you miss a day, simply pick up where you left off. Forcing yourself through a practice about not forcing would miss the point. Go gently. That is the whole idea.

DAY

1

Muddy Water

Let it be still, and it will gradually become clear.

CHAPTER 15

Sit for five minutes today and do nothing at all. When thoughts stir, do not fight them; simply stop stirring them further. Notice whether anything settles by itself.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

2

The Empty Vessel

The Tao is (like) the emptiness of a vessel; and in our employment of it we must be on our guard against all fulness.

CHAPTER 4

Look at your calendar for today and find one gap you could leave open. Protect it. When it comes, do not fill it with your phone; let it stay empty and see what it is like.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

3

The Use of Space

Clay is fashioned into vessels; but it is on their empty hollowness, that their use depends.

CHAPTER 11

Clear one surface in your home: a table, a shelf, a corner of your desk. Leave it bare for the rest of the day. Each time you pass it, notice how the empty space feels.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

4

Returning to the Root

When things (in the vegetable world)
have displayed their luxuriant growth,
we see each of them return to its root.

CHAPTER 16

Spend a few minutes outdoors with a tree or a plant. Think of what it draws back into its roots in winter. Then ask yourself what you could draw back from today, to rest and gather strength.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

5

Fewer Words

Much speech to swift exhaustion lead we see

CHAPTER 5

Speak a little less today. In one conversation, let a pause go by before you answer, and leave out the sentence you do not need. Notice how much energy your words usually take.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

6

Not Too Full

It is better to leave a vessel unfilled, than to attempt to carry it when it is full.

CHAPTER 9

Stop one thing a little before it is "full": eat until you are almost satisfied, end a work session while you still have energy, leave a task at good enough. See how it feels to carry less.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

7

Your Center

Gravity is the root of lightness;
stillness, the ruler of movement.

CHAPTER 26

Before each busy part of your day, take three slow breaths and feel your feet on the floor. Return to that weight whenever you feel yourself being pulled in many directions.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

8

Like Water

The highest excellence is like (that of) water.

CHAPTER 8

Watch water closely today: in a glass, in the shower, in the rain. Notice how it takes the shape of what holds it without losing itself. Where in your life could you be a little more like that?

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

9

Bending

The partial becomes complete; the crooked, straight; the empty, full; the worn out, new.

CHAPTER 22

Think of one thing in your life that feels unfinished, bent, or worn out. Instead of judging it, ask what it might be making room for. Write down one possibility.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

10

Soft and Hard

The soft overcomes the hard; and the weak the strong.

CHAPTER 36

The next time you meet resistance today, from a person or a task, try softening instead of pushing harder. Lower your voice, loosen your grip, ask a question. Watch what changes.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

11

Finding the Crevice

The softest thing in the world dashes against and overcomes the hardest; that which has no (substantial) existence enters where there is no crevice.

CHAPTER 43

Pick a problem you have been attacking head-on without success. Today, look for the quiet way in: a small step, a side door, a patient approach. Try it once.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

12

Staying Supple

Man at his birth is supple and weak; at his death, firm and strong.

CHAPTER 76

Notice one opinion you hold rigidly. Today, listen to someone who sees it differently, without trying to win. Also give your body a few minutes of gentle stretching, as a reminder of what suppleness feels like.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

13

Blunting the Edge

We should blunt our sharp points, and unravel the complications of things

CHAPTER 4

Before you send a message today, read it again and soften one sharp phrase. If something feels tangled, untie just one knot of it rather than all of them at once.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

14

From Knowing to Doing

Every one in the world knows that the soft overcomes the hard, and the weak the strong, but no one is able to carry it out in practice.

CHAPTER 78

Look back over this week. Where did you manage to yield, and where did you push? Choose one situation coming up tomorrow and decide in advance how you will meet it softly.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

15

Rich Enough

He who is satisfied with his lot is rich

CHAPTER 33

Write down ten things you already have that you are glad of, from the large to the very small. Read the list once in the evening before you sleep.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

16

The Wish to Be Getting

There is no guilt greater than to sanction ambition; no calamity greater than to be discontented with one's lot; no fault greater than the wish to be getting.

CHAPTER 46

Each time you feel the urge to buy, check, or acquire something today, pause and name the feeling underneath it. You do not have to resist every time. Just notice.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

17

Too Much Input

Colour's five hues from th' eyes their sight will take

CHAPTER 12

Reduce the noise for one part of the day: no music in the background, no scrolling, no second screen. Then eat one meal slowly and taste it fully.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

18

Less Each Day

he who devotes himself to the Tao (seeks)
from day to day to diminish (his doing).

CHAPTER 48

Remove one thing from your to-do list without doing it, because it does not really matter. Then let go of one object you no longer need.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

19

The Uncarved Block

The unwrought material, when
divided and distributed, forms vessels.

CHAPTER 28

Spend a quiet moment remembering yourself before your titles and roles. What did you love as a child, before anyone told you what to be? Do one small thing today in that spirit.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

20

Few Desires

He whose (desires) are few gets them; he whose (desires) are many goes astray.

CHAPTER 22

Write down what you want this week. Then cross out everything except the three wishes that matter most. Give your attention only to those.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

21

Simple Pleasures

They should think their (coarse) food sweet; their (plain) clothes beautiful; their (poor) dwellings places of rest; and their common (simple) ways sources of enjoyment.

CHAPTER 80

Enjoy something plain today on purpose: bread, tea, a walk around the block, your own bed. Give it the attention you would give a treat.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

22

Doing Without Forcing

The Tao in its regular course does nothing (for the sake of doing it), and so there is nothing which it does not do.

CHAPTER 37

Choose one task today and do it without strain: no rushing, no clenched jaw, no fighting it. Do only what the task needs, and then stop.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

23

A Single Step

the journey of a thousand li
commenced with a single step.

CHAPTER 64

Think of a large goal you keep postponing. Take one step toward it today, so small that it would be silly not to: one email, one page, five minutes.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

24

While It Is Small

(The master of it) anticipates things that are difficult while they are easy, and does things that would become great while they are small.

CHAPTER 63

Look for one small problem at work or at home that could grow if it is left alone. Deal with it today, while it is still easy.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

25

A Light Touch

Governing a great state is like cooking small fish.

CHAPTER 60

Small fish fall apart if you keep turning them. Today, resist the urge to check, correct, or stir something that is already going well. Trust it and leave it alone.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

26

Leading from Behind

Their work was done and their undertakings were successful, while the people all said, 'We are as we are, of ourselves!'

CHAPTER 17

Help someone today in a way that lets them feel they did it themselves. Offer a question instead of an answer, or quietly prepare the ground and step aside.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

27

Lower Than the Streams

So it is that the sage (ruler), wishing to be above men, puts himself by his words below them, and, wishing to be before them, places his person behind them.

CHAPTER 66

Serve someone today without being asked: let another speak first, take the smaller share, do a chore no one notices. Watch how it changes the mood around you.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

28

Good to All

To those who are good (to me), I am good; and to those who are not good (to me), I am also good;—and thus (all) get to be good.

CHAPTER 49

Think of one person you find difficult. Today, offer them a small kindness that does not depend on how they treat you. This does not mean accepting harm; it means not letting their mood set yours.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

29

Careful at the End

If they were careful at the end, as (they should be) at the beginning, they would not so ruin them.

CHAPTER 64

Look back over the past four weeks and your notes. Which day changed something for you? Which was hardest? Write down the three practices you most want to keep.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

DAY

30

Carrying It Out

Scholars of the highest class, when they hear about the Tao, earnestly carry it into practice.

CHAPTER 41

Choose one practice from this month to continue for the next thirty days. Write it down in a single sentence and put it where you will see it each morning. Then begin again, gently.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ sat in stillness ☐ one step taken

Quick Finder

Looking for something specific? Find the situation closest to yours, then turn to the chapters listed and, if you like, to the matching day of the 30-Day Practice.

When your mind will not settle — Chapter 15, Chapter 16 · Day 1

When you feel overwhelmed and overbooked — Chapter 4, Chapter 11 · Day 2

When you are running on empty — Chapter 9, Chapter 16 · Day 4

When you talk too much, or regret what you said — Chapter 5, Chapter 56 · Day 5

When you are pulled in too many directions — Chapter 26, Chapter 47 · Day 7

When you want to win an argument — Chapter 8, Chapter 22, Chapter 81 · Day 13

When you meet resistance and want to push harder — Chapter 36, Chapter 43, Chapter 78 · Day 10

When you feel stuck in your own opinions — Chapter 76, Chapter 71 · Day 12

When something in your life feels broken or unfinished — Chapter 22, Chapter 45 · Day 9

When you crave recognition or praise — Chapter 13, Chapter 24 · Day 27

When you never feel you have enough — Chapter 33, Chapter 44, Chapter 46 · Day 15

When you want to buy, collect, or acquire — Chapter 12, Chapter 46 · Day 16

When there is too much noise and stimulation — Chapter 12, Chapter 20 · Day 17

When you want to simplify your life — Chapter 19, Chapter 48, Chapter 80 · Day 18

When you have lost touch with who you really are — Chapter 28, Chapter 32 · Day 19

When you are trying too hard — Chapter 37, Chapter 48, Chapter 63 · Day 22

When a big goal feels impossible — Chapter 63, Chapter 64 · Day 23

When a small problem is starting to grow — Chapter 63, Chapter 64 · Day 24

When you lead a team or a family — Chapter 17, Chapter 60, Chapter 66 · Day 26

When you are tempted to micromanage — Chapter 57, Chapter 60 · Day 25

When success goes to your head — Chapter 9, Chapter 22, Chapter 77 · Day 27

When someone treats you badly — Chapter 49, Chapter 63, Chapter 79 · Day 28

When a conflict is turning toward a fight — Chapter 30, Chapter 31, Chapter 68, Chapter 69 · Day 10

When you fear change or loss — Chapter 16, Chapter 58, Chapter 76 · Day 4

When you want to give more freely — Chapter 7, Chapter 81 · Day 28

A Glossary

abasement — Legge's word for lowering oneself, placing oneself beneath others. In the *Tao Te Ching* this is a strength, not a humiliation (Chapter 61).

attemper — An old word meaning to soften, tone down, or moderate. "We should attemper our brightness" means: do not dazzle others (Chapters 4 and 56).

benevolence and righteousness — Two central virtues of Confucian teaching: kindness toward others and doing what is morally right. The *Tao Te Ching* argues that people only start preaching them once the natural Way has been lost (Chapters 18, 19, 38).

buff coat — A coat of thick leather worn as armor (Chapters 50 and 80).

the dogs of grass — Figures of dogs woven from straw and used in ancient sacrifices. They were treated with great care during the ceremony and thrown away afterward. The image shows that heaven and earth play no favorites (Chapter 5).

emptiness — Open, unfilled space, which the book values as the source of usefulness: the hollow of a bowl, the hub of a wheel, a mind free of clutter. Legge also calls it "vacancy" (Chapters 4, 11, 16).

the female, the mother — Images for the Tao as the quiet, receptive source that gives birth to all things and nourishes them without claiming them (Chapters 1, 6, 25, 52, 61).

filial — Showing the respect and care a child owes to parents, a key duty in traditional Chinese ethics (Chapters 18 and 19).

heaven and earth — The sky above and the ground below; together, the whole natural world. "Heaven" in this book usually means the order of nature, not a paradise or a personal god (Chapters 5, 7, 23, 77).

hests — Commands or orders (Chapter 68).

host and guest — In Chapter 69, the "host" is the side that starts a war, the "guest" the side that only defends itself.

the infant, the babe — An image of the natural state: soft, whole, full of life, not yet shaped by ambition or fear (Chapters 10, 20, 28, 55).

the intelligent and animal souls — Legge's rendering of two aspects of the self in old Chinese belief, roughly the mind and the bodily life force, which should be kept together in one embrace (Chapter 10).

knotted cords — A way of keeping records by tying knots in string, used before writing. The book holds it up as a sign of a simpler age (Chapter 80).

leal-heartedness — Loyalty and sincerity; "leal" is an old Scots and English word for loyal (Chapter 38).

li — A traditional Chinese measure of distance, roughly a third of a mile, though its length varied over time. "The journey of a thousand li" is a long journey indeed (Chapter 64).

manes — The spirits of the dead, a Latin word Legge used for Chinese beliefs about ancestral and other spirits (Chapter 60).

nave — The hub at the center of a wheel, into which the spokes are fitted (Chapters 11 and 39).

non-action — Legge's term for *wu wei*: not inaction, but action without forcing or self-seeking (Chapters 43 and 48). See *wu wei*.

the One — The unity of the Tao itself, or the state of being whole and undivided. Things that "have got the One" are what they are meant to be (Chapters 14, 39, 42).

propriety, the proprieties — The rules of ritual and correct behavior, highly valued in Confucian teaching. Chapter 38 calls them a thin shadow of

real sincerity.

the sage — The wise person, often a wise ruler, who lives by the Way: leading without pushing, teaching without lecturing, and doing good without claiming credit.

the six kinships — The closest family relations, such as parents, siblings, spouse, and children (Chapter 18).

the Son of Heaven — The traditional title of the Chinese king or emperor, seen as ruling by the mandate of heaven (Chapter 62).

the superior man — The person of noble character, a key ideal in Confucian thought (Chapter 31).

tallies — Sticks or tokens used for counting and keeping accounts (Chapter 27).

Tao — "The Way." The source and pattern of all things, which cannot be fully named or described. Legge wrote it "Tâo."

Te — "Virtue" or "power": the natural strength of one who lives in harmony with the Tao. Legge wrote it "Teh," and often renders it as "the attributes (of the Tao)."

the ten thousand things — A Chinese way of saying "everything that exists." Legge usually translates it simply as "all things."

'tis, 'twas, e'er, ne'er, th' — Shortened poetic forms of "it is," "it was," "ever," "never," and "the," used in Legge's rhymed passages.

the uncarved block — Wood that has not yet been shaped into anything; an image of our simple, natural state. Legge calls it "the unwrought material," "wood that has not been fashioned into anything," or simply "simplicity" (Chapters 15, 19, 28, 32, 37, 57).

the valley — A low, open, receptive place where waters gather. It stands for humility, openness, and the hidden source of life (Chapters 6, 15, 28, 39, 66).

vessel — A bowl, jar, or cup. It appears both as an image of usefulness through emptiness and as a warning against filling oneself too full (Chapters 4, 9,

11, 28).

water — The book's central image of the Way: soft and yielding, always seeking the low place, benefiting all things, and yet stronger than stone (Chapters 8, 66, 78).

wu wei — "Not doing" or "non-forcing action." Acting in tune with the nature of things, without strain, self-display, or meddling, so that what needs doing gets done (Chapters 2, 37, 48, 63, 64).

yin and yang — The two complementary forces in Chinese thought: dark and light, soft and hard, receptive and active. In the *Tao Te Ching* they are named only in Chapter 42, which Legge renders as "the Obscurity" and "the Brightness."

Afterword: The Way of Water

If you remember only one image from the *Tao Te Ching*, let it be water.

The book returns to it again and again. "The highest excellence is like (that of) water," says Chapter 8. Water gives life to every living thing and asks for nothing back. It does not argue about where it goes. It simply flows toward the lowest place, the place "which all men dislike," and settles there. And yet, as Chapter 78 reminds us, there is nothing softer or weaker than water, and nothing better at wearing down what is hard.

This is a strange kind of strength, and most of us were never taught it. We learned to push, to compete, to hold our ground and raise our voice. Sometimes that works. But often it only makes the wall we are pushing against harder. Water shows another way. It does not attack the rock. It goes around it, finds the crack, keeps coming back, and over time the rock gives way.

Water also teaches patience. Stir a muddy pond and it only gets darker. Leave it alone and the mud sinks by itself. Many of our troubles are like that: the more we churn them, the cloudier they become. Sometimes the wisest thing is to stop, and let the water clear.

And water teaches humility. Rivers and seas, says Chapter 66, rule over all the streams of the valleys because they lie lower than all of them. The people we trust most are often like this. They do not need to be first. They make room, they listen, and others come to them naturally.

None of this means being passive. Water is never idle. It carves canyons and turns mill wheels. But it does its work without forcing, and when the work is done, it moves on without asking for praise.

You have now read eighty-one chapters, and perhaps lived thirty days of practice. The book does not ask you to remember all of it. It only asks you to keep returning, the way water returns to the sea. Begin again tomorrow, softly. That is enough.

Further Reading

If the *Tao Te Ching* has spoken to you, these classics, all available in public-domain translations, make good companions.

Chuang Tzu, *Chuang Tzu: Mystic, Moralist, and Social Reformer*, translated by Herbert A. Giles (1889). The second great classic of Taoism, full of stories, jokes, and dreams. The best next step after Lao Tzu.

The Texts of Taoism, translated by James Legge (1891). *The Sacred Books of the East*, volumes 39 and 40, containing Legge's translation of the *Tao Te Ching* together with his complete rendering of the *Chuang Tzu*.

Confucius, *The Analects*, translated by James Legge (1861). The sayings of the teacher whose ideas the *Tao Te Ching* so often answers. Reading the two side by side shows both in a new light.

The I Ching, translated by James Legge (1882). The ancient *Book of Changes*, from which much Chinese thinking about change, balance, and timing grew. Published in *The Sacred Books of the East*, volume 16.

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*, translated by George Long (1862). The private notebook of a Roman emperor who tried to live with calm, simplicity, and acceptance. From a very different world, it shares much with the spirit of Lao Tzu. It is available in this same annotated series.